

THE *SCORCHING* EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY



A  
**KILLER**  
OF A  
**ONE NIGHT STAND**

EPISODE FIVE

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR

**MAX SEBASTIAN**



THE **SCORCHING** EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A woman with long, wavy red hair is shown from the waist up, wearing a black bra and matching underwear. She is looking over her shoulder towards the camera. The background is a textured, light blue wall. The title text is overlaid on the image.

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A woman with long, wavy red hair is standing against a textured blue wall. She is wearing a black bra, black gloves, and black underwear. She is looking over her shoulder towards the camera.

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## About the Author

Max Sebastian has written more than 20 novels, and regularly tops the bestseller lists for steamy erotic fiction. He began writing erotica at Literotica.com nearly two decades ago, and broke into the wider world of publishing in 2011.

Since then, Max has become well-known for sensual, steamy adventures in which couples explore thrilling alternatives to monogamous relationships, on their way to a very raunchy happy ever after—including menage stories, wife-sharing, hotwives, cuckolding and partner-swapping in various forms.

Max lives in London, England, and loves to hear from readers. Visit his website at [www.maxsebastian.net](http://www.maxsebastian.net).

## Some of Max's Other Books

**Web: [MaxSebastian.net](http://MaxSebastian.net)**

[Anarchy of the Heart](#)

[Submitting to Her](#)

[The Madeleine Trilogy](#)

[What's Mine Is Yours](#)

[What's Yours Is Mine](#)

[The Game](#)

[She's a Star](#)

[Heidi, Corrupted](#)

[His Week With My Wife](#)

[Out of His League \(with Kenny Wright\)](#)

[Rock Her World](#)

[The One That I Married](#)

[Game Changer](#)

[Obsessive Trilogy](#)

[Marriage 2.0](#)

[A Lockdown Affair](#)

A Killer of a One Night Stand

Episode Five

Max Sebastian

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## Chapter 7

### **Prologue**

“Tell me how you got it, tell me how you got that code.”

“So you do think it’s important, right?”

“Potentially, yes. But I don’t know how you came by it. I mean, if it was just some torn piece of newspaper blowing around the street...”

“No, it was handed to me. It was expressly given to me as some kind of... I don’t know... reward.”

“Reward?”

“Okay. So I slept with some guy’s wife, and on the way out, they handed me this piece of card...”

“You slept with some guy’s wife. And ‘they’ handed you the card? What, so the guy was there? The husband?”

“Yeah, sounds a little messed up, huh?”

“Look, you’re going to have to tell me from the beginning.”



The sports centre was just a stone’s throw from Nate’s apartment, and just across a narrow waterway from Canary Wharf, with the imposing glass towers of the financial district looming overhead to the west, the lights blazing in the early evening darkness. It was where a lot of financial workers came to unwind after work, and Jonah had been once or twice before to meet his brother after a five-a-side game.

He found Nate’s old colleague Graham sitting there at a table outside the centre’s Sports Bar, wearing a white polo shirt and shorts, perspiration still on his brow as he sat there sipping from one of the two pints of lager resting in front of him.

“So let me get this straight,” Jonah said, perching on the picnic table-style bench.

“You’re afraid for your life because of what you know. But you’re willing to come back to Canary Wharf for five-a-side football?”

Graham gently shook his head, and looked Jonah in the eye quite gravely as he pushed one of the beers over to him. “Dodgeball.”

“Dodgeball?”

He smiled, “We’re in the play-offs. If I didn’t show up, the rest of my team would track me down and kill me anyway.”

Jonah took a sip of the sharp, cold lager—his first in a while. Always tasted better after a break. Heart grew fonder, he guessed. Like with Emma. Then he’d said, “You want to go somewhere, though, now it’s over? Somewhere safer?”

Graham just shrugged, “I don’t know. Maybe I was being a little paranoid. Keep looking over my shoulder, you know? And there’s nothing there, really.”

“You weren’t paranoid about Selmer being killed. And with him involved with Nate in those unusual trades...”

Jonah pulled a piece of white card from his pocket—the card that he was given at the end of his evening with Victoria and the other guy, Liam. The card that bore only the printed letters “RMZ”.

“So this is it?”

Jonah nodded. “The guy, whose wife I was with, was in the City. He didn’t bat an eyelid when I was given this. Thought you might know what it refers to.”

Graham shrugged. “Could be various things. Tell me how you got it. Tell me from the beginning.”

Jonah sighed. He said, “You remember back when you told me Nate had been using dating websites to hook up with women?”

“Yes, of course.”

“That was just as I was starting to do it myself. I don’t know... probably seems a little insane. I was trying to recreate what he was up to—using the same website to meet women. I even pretended to be the kind of City boy Nate was.”

“And when I told you he happened to like married women?” Graham asked.

Jonah nodded. “It helped me narrow the search—if Nate had mainly dated married women, for whatever reason, I would too.”

“And by doing that, you stumbled on this whole share-dealing scheme?”

He shrugged. “I had help, here and there. The detective the police have liaising with the victims’ next-of-kin—Detective Mulray—has taken more of a co-operative approach to my dabbling in the investigation than the guy she replaced. She introduced me to the first murder victim’s wife, Lily Foster. Her husband was Julian Foster.”

“He was the journalist, right? The victim who wasn’t directly connected to the City.”

“That’s right. And she used to be the kind of married woman who would meet guys like my brother for sex—with her husband’s consent.”

“Okay,” Graham nodded. “So that was a coincidence, huh?”

Jonah took a sip of his beer. “Well, anyway. She helped me understand the mindset. Julian wrote a book about that whole world—wife-sharing, they call it.

It was self-published or vanity-published, so it didn’t get a real distribution other than by Julian himself selling or giving out copies to people he knew. Then

Detective Mulray and I went to talk to the widow of another victim—Lord Moss

—and I found a copy of Julian’s book on one of her bookshelves.”



“So Julian Foster must have known Lord Moss, right? And if they had his book, chances were...”

Jonah nodded. “Well, Julian Foster was writing about Lord Moss in his professional career, so he interviewed the guy. But the fact that the wife-sharing book ended up in Lord or Lady Moss’s possession—well, that was indication that they might have a shared interest in that direction.”

“Another connection.”

“Anyway, with this other friend of mine, we were eventually able to access Julian Foster’s account on that dating website—and it seemed that he was writing another book about all that stuff, and interviewing people for it. We saw that he interviewed Nate for the book—”

“Another connection. Beginning to see how all this investigation stuff works.”

Jonah shrugged, “It doesn’t always end up with concrete answers, though.

Through Julian’s account on that website, we were able to find Nate’s user name, and so access Nate’s account. And he had a list of potential dates—women whose profiles he liked on that website, and who he intended to—possibly—ask out on a date.”

“Okay, so you think—”

“We thought perhaps one of those women might be the killer. I’ve been attempting to ask those women out, and on the first date the woman was asking me all about my fake profile as a City trader. I told her everything I knew about Nate’s job, about your firm. Then my next date with a woman from that list—

well,” Jonah looked either side of them, but the outside part of the bar was empty other than the two of them. It wasn’t exactly a warm evening.

He continued: “It was all set up so I slept with a woman in front of her husband.

And there was another guy sleeping with her while I was.”

Graham chuckled, “Threesome, eh? Nate had a few of those. Or at least, he strongly hinted that he did.”

“And that was where we were given that card with the code printed on it. RMZ. I don’t know... it felt organized. It wasn’t just a date, those women on the list Nate had, they were part of some larger organization, I’m sure of it. The other guy having sex with the woman seemed to do that kind of thing all the time—

and he didn’t bat an eyelid about being given that code.”

Graham nodded, “So it must happen a lot. People bang wives. Codes get given to them. Seems like an organization, huh. One that’s trying to fiddle the stock market. Jesus.”

“So that’s what you think it is?”

“RMZ. It’s probably needle in haystack stuff, but there is a paper company with

‘RMZ’ as its ticker symbol.”

“You mean for its shares, right? The code for its shares.”

“Uh-huh.” Graham had taken a big swig of beer just then, and though he seemed to have relaxed about the threats to his life, Jonah noticed his eyes still darting this way and that, checking and re-checking for anything suspicious around them. “Actually, it’s precisely the kind of company I’ve been looking into, with these numbers from Nate’s accounts.”

“How so?”

“Well, it’s a big-ish company, decent enough market cap, so plenty of shares around for the trading. But times have fallen a bit flat recently.”

“What are you saying, that’s the same kind of company Nate was investing in?”

Another quick movement of Graham’s eyes, left and right, and then a nod. “It fits the profile. Pretty stable trading, you’re not going to see a sudden collapse in the share price, chances are. But nothing special has

happened to it for months, maybe even a year or two. And then the demand suddenly starts going up—and for no particular reason.”

Jonah said: “What are you saying? Something suspicious?”

“Not enough to trigger the alarms, catch the regulator’s eyes. And then things tail off after a while. Somebody made a packet or two in the process, though.”

“And Nate’s trading fell into that category, right? He made some big gains on those kind of companies?”

“Exactly,” Graham nodded. “RMZ—Rameses Paper Company—was pretty big, edging into the FTSE 250 in the mid-1990s. Then it slipped a bit—the digital revolution, right? Everyone going onto the Internet, less use for paper. Only in recent years, online shopping’s come along. Suddenly, everybody needs a ton of cardboard boxes. And who makes cardboard boxes?”

“Paper companies.”

“Right. So it’s got its trade back. Online shopping is growing nicely, but there’s competition for the trade. RMZ does okay, but it’s not lighting on fire. Then suddenly, without so much as a quarterly results statement, the share price goes up.”

“When did it go up?”

“Pretty soon after you got handed that card with the letters on. It’s still going up steadily as we speak.”

Jonah took a sip of beer. “So you think it’s dodgy. Some kind of... I don’t know... manipulation of the market.”

“Ripe candidate, isn’t it? And when you look at the other companies where it happened the same way, you have to think something funny’s going on.”

“I can’t believe Nate would be caught up in this.”

“Well, it depends how it was sold to him. Just a little harmless fun, see if a few mates can do enough together to inspire any kind of movement.

Nobody really suffers. Share prices go down as well as up, and all that,” Graham said, slurping the dregs of his glass. “We’ve seen it in Libor, we’ve seen it in Forex. Young guns just messing about.”

“Right. All those banks paying massive fines because the bankers were rigging the markets...”

Graham nodded. “Only, the thing about the stock market is, you’d need a heck of a lot of traders to get that kind of movement. A heck of a lot. So that

organization you found—well, it must be pretty big.”

## **One**

The whole way to his next date, he was checking his mobile phone for text messages.

Jonah was nervous—and for perhaps the first time, he wasn’t nervous about his date. Emma had walked out on him, under the impression he’d been sleeping with Lily Foster behind her back. He’d tried calling her, leaving voicemail messages, sending email and text messages, and all had been ignored.

It left him feeling crushed inside—and revealed to him how dependent on her he had come to be, at least emotionally.

So what to do about their murder investigation? He couldn’t bring it all to a halt just because he no longer had his trusty sidekick.

After a day or two, Jonah felt certain he had to continue his efforts to go through the list of women his brother had earmarked for dating, any of whom could have been the woman who had gone on that final date, the one who had killed him.

He had to keep arranging the one night stands that, he was certain, were bringing him closer to the murderer. He also had to find out more about this strange network of non-monogamous couples that seemed to connect all the victims of the Black Widow in one way or another.

So, via the No Strings website, he’d accepted the offer of an evening with a beautiful redhead by the name of Lydia, despite knowing that Emma



would not be there to monitor the situation.

On the evening of the date itself, just as he was stepping out of Nate's apartment building to track down a taxi, Emma texted him:

*>Thought we agreed you wouldn't go on these dates alone any more—it's not safe.*

Reading it, he felt both the uplifting sensation of hope that Emma was still

interested in him, she hadn't gone for good—and also the frustration of mild injustice. It even infuriated him a little, that she had walked out on him and not responded to any of his attempts to explain himself, then chastised him for trying to do something without her.

Having spent days almost grieving the loss of the woman he was increasingly certain he loved, he now felt aggrieved by her attitude.

He'd texted her back:

*>I would love nothing more than for you to come along, but you've not been returning my calls*

Walking across the steel bridge over the choppy waters of the North Dock, Jonah had been peering at the little screen of his smartphone, hoping the text conversation with Emma might continue. Before hailing a cab up at Cabot Square, he'd even tried calling her—but once again she did not pick up.

Pride kept him from doing any more to respond to her. He'd called, he'd texted.

He didn't want to seem like a stalker.

Nevertheless, he spent the whole taxi ride to West London glancing at that dark screen, hoping it might light up any moment with a new text from her.



The taxi dropped him off a couple of blocks away from the hotel since he was somewhat early for his date. This was Chelsea, another well-to-do part of central London, bolstering the idea that this Network that Jonah was now beginning to circulate within was firmly enshrined within the affluent classes.

The hotel was within a long row of Georgian townhouses, the lower floor clad in white stucco while the upper floors remained bare brick. Black cast iron railings ran around steps leading down to a lower ground floor.

Was this even a hotel? There was no sign outside. Jonah double-checked the address, and was certain he was at the right place.

He was about to go inside when he was startled by the sound of a car door opening.

“You’re in the right place,” came a disturbingly familiar voice.

He turned to find none other than Detective Mulray stepping out of her vehicle.

He felt a little stupid for not spotting her parked there, but then he simply hadn’t been looking at the cars.

“I suppose I’m obliged to ask you what the hell you’re doing here,” he said, trying to remain calm.

Was his identity blown? Was all this progress getting into the wife-sharing organization now for nothing?

She smiled, then handed him a pair of glasses. He didn’t need to examine them to know they were Emma’s, the glasses containing a tiny video camera.

“Someone has to make sure you’re safe,” she said.

Jonah found himself blushing. Did Mulray really expect him just to let her watch him on his date, whatever this date turned out to be?

“Emma sent you?”

She gave a half-smile. “What did you say to her? She’s very upset with you.”

He sighed, “She thinks I slept with Lily Foster after she made it clear she preferred me not to.”

“And did you sleep with her?”

“No.”

Mulray’s gaze flickered from one of his eyes to the other, and back again. Assessing him.

Finally, after a few moments, she nodded. She believed him, then?

“Since when were you two such good friends?” he asked the Detective.

Mulray smiled. “She has an interesting perspective.”

Jonah handed back the glasses—or tried to. “If she wants to watch me, she needs to do it herself.”

The Detective shook her head, refusing to take the glasses from him. “I have my instructions. And so do you if you want to keep going with all this.”

He sighed. “What are you saying, you’ll stop helping me if I don’t let you do this?”

“I may not need your help in my investigation, if that’s what you mean,” she said.

“And if I let you?”

She shrugged, “I’d probably consider you of interest again.”

Jesus. What was Emma playing at? Objecting to him having anything to do with Lily Foster, and getting a beautiful woman like DI Mulray to observe one of his evening encounters. He’d always had a little crush on the stunning Detective, but then Emma wouldn’t know that.

Yes, there was that little tickle of arousal inside him at the thought of Mulray taking any kind of interest in him sexually, even if it was supposedly a professional interest, monitoring his undercover operations within the online

dating community. But that only made him feel guilty, and that if Emma found out that he was attracted to Mulray in any way, she would continue to be angry at him.

“Come on,” Mulray put something in his hand. He saw that it was the earpiece, the tiny little thing that had previously put Emma’s voice in his ear. “Stop thinking to yourself that you have choice in any of this. You’re going to be late.”

He took a step back, away from her and toward the hotel’s front entrance.

“If you’re winding me up, I won’t be happy,” he said.

“Get going, Romeo,” she said, holding up what he saw to be an iPad. The iPad she would be watching him from.

“Christ,” he said.

She grinned, “I promise not to arrest you for being a man-whore.”

He took another step back, said with more than a hint of sarcasm: “Thanks so much.”

“Just try to forget I’m here.”

As he ventured up to the hotel entrance, he found himself hoping this all turned out to be nothing. That his date, one Lydia Morgan, would want only a nice meal and the possibility of something in future, rather than a full one night stand while he had Mulray watching. Or perhaps she’d stand him up completely.

But this was a network. Lydia Morgan was a woman who had received recommendations about Jonah—or at least his alter ego Robert—via the network. She wouldn’t be the type to bail on a night of passion.

The front door wasn’t marked at all—if this was a hotel, how were guests supposed to know they were in the right place? And surely the hotel

owners would want to attract walk-ins by at least telling people on the street that this hotel was here?

There wasn't any kind of intercom that an apartment block might have. He wondered if he should knock. Instead, he tried simply turning the ornate brass

door handle—and it opened easily.

Inside, he found himself in a brightly-lit hall that appeared to be the lobby of a small but upmarket hotel. He felt relief that he was in the right place.

There were a few expensive-looking sofas lining the walnut-paneled walls, but the biggest giveaway was the small reception desk at the far end of the space.

“Uh... I'm here to meet Lydia Morgan,” he said to the fifty-something receptionist who looked up at him only when he came to a halt in front of her counter.

“The Morgan party?” she asked, and he groaned at the thought that it was some kind of party he was walking into with Mulray watching. “They'll be dining at present. Please hold on a moment.”

She reached for an intercom handset, and murmured something into it.

He took a step back, turned to admire a work of art that looked like a five-year-old might have produced, but which no doubt sold for a good six-figure sum.

“You like it?” came the voice in his ear. “Thought you had better taste than that.”

He whispered, “I thought I was supposed to forget you were there.”

“Only if it... affects your performance.”

He sighed, and heard her laugh. There was a slight thickening between his legs.

It turned out he quite liked making the pretty detective laugh.



Then he heard a man's voice from behind him, which snapped him out of his thoughts. "Robert?"

"Yes, that's me."

A gray-haired man, perhaps in his early fifties, stood there in dinner attire, smiling warmly at him. Jonah took his offered hand, shook it.

"Good of you to come," the man said. He didn't seem stiff enough to be a butler or a servant of some kind, his tuxedo perhaps a little too luxurious.

"Of course," Jonah said, and followed him down the hallway, around a corner and to a large set of white double doors.

"Deep breath," came Mulray's voice in his ear, just to taunt him.

"Shhh!" he hissed at her as quietly as he could.

"I'm sorry?" The man had heard.

Jonah coughed politely into a fist, trying to make the man believe he simply had a little tickle in his throat. The man nodded, buying the story.

Inside, the room was much darker than the hallway outside, lit only by candles flickering from a tall candelabra in the centre of a lavish dining table. Jonah counted twelve diners seated around the table, including the man who had shown him into the room.

Couples, it seemed, though the men were generally a little older than the women, and for some of the couples the age gap was significant. There were two women above the age of fifty, Jonah would have said. The others seem to range from early thirties to mid-forties. The men were invariably fifty-somethings, with a few who might have been knocking on the door of sixty.

A beautiful thirty-something redhead seated next to the empty chair, which must have belonged to Jonah's host, now stood, smiling in his direction, and took a couple of steps toward them.

"My wife, Lydia," the host said, a note of pride in his voice.

"Hello," she said, approaching him, holding up her hand for a kiss.

“Very nice to meet you,” Jonah said, feeling all the eyes in the room on him as he bent to kiss her soft, pale hand.

She was wearing a long black dress that looked to be made of satin. It shimmered slightly in the light of the candles. Reaching down to her ankles, it nevertheless clung to her figure so tightly that it left little to the imagination.

Jonah could even see her nipples pushing up through the thin material.

Somewhat startling for evening wear.

“Wow,” came Mulray’s judgement in his ear. He tried to ignore her.

He saw the redhead look at her husband, who had a clear question imprinted in his features. Asking her, silently, if Jonah was acceptable.

“Thank you,” she said to him, stating her approval.

The gray-haired man turned to Jonah, said: “Be gentle with her.”

Jonah nodded. “Of course.”

He glanced around him, and saw the couples all looking at them, smiling at this strange display—which probably wasn’t strange to them, though it was plain weird for Jonah. It just looked like a regular dinner party, albeit for some clearly wealthy couples. These were the friends of this couple, and they were watching their host give away his wife to this stranger.

You expected these guys to talk about the schools they sent their kids to, perhaps something about politics. The plans they had for Christmas and New Year in some far-flung paradise.

But they were watching, riveted to their seats, as the beautiful redhead took Jonah’s hand and escorted him to the door, with only a brief glance back at her husband before she stepped out of the room, her new man behind her.

“It’s really as easy as that?” Mulray said as Jonah escorted Lydia into the hotel lobby. “I guess you’re really in with this crowd now.”

The receptionist didn't even raise an eyebrow as Lydia walked with Jonah through to the gold plated doors of the elevator. She must have known something unseemly was going on.

The elevator walls were mirrored, giving Jonah multiple views of this tall, elegant woman.

"You're experienced?" she said, her voice quiet, her eyes running down his body now, aided by the mirrors around them.

"I am," he said. Well, the word was so subjective, of course he could say he was experienced.

She nodded. "I've... we've only been part of the Network a little while. I didn't know what to expect."

Jonah nodded, and silently decided that her inexperience in the Network, if that was what she was calling it, might allow him to get a question or two in, without raising her suspicions. He said, "Was it your husband's idea to get involved in all this, or yours?"

"My husband's. He heard about it, of course, on the grapevine. Didn't think much until we got a little older, and he became a senior director."

She slipped her fingers under one of the thin straps holding up her dress, pushing it off over her shoulder. Then the other. The dress dropped to the floor.

Underneath she was wearing a black strapless bra that was so sheer it was almost as though her breasts were bare.

"But he wanted to... to share you?"

Her breasts were not large, did not need a huge amount of support. Perky, though.

She said, "At first, he was interested in the networking, would you believe it.

Had big doubts about the rest of it."

She was wearing a black suspender belt and stockings that went with her bra—

but no panties. Jonah thought he was imagining that last part, though quick glances down there, and in the mirror, confirmed it.

“What was it changed his mind?”

She stepped up to him, her hands pressing against his chest. But though she leaned in her face, she didn’t kiss him. She smelled him.

“The first time he watched me with another man,” she said. “It was like some kind of switch flipped inside him. Couldn’t get enough of it after that.”

“And you? You’re happy to go along with it?”

“Are you kidding? What I get to do...” Her mouth creased into a smile. “I have the perfect husband.”

Her hand fell on his crotch, scoping out the bulge in his pants. It was a testament to how strange his online dating life had become that he wasn’t bursting at the seams at the sight of the nearly naked beauty in front of him. “Hmm...

potential,” she smirked. He heard through his earpiece Mulray stifling her laugh.

Jonah said, trying to avoid being seen as a lemon, “You do this often?”

She stepped back, her hands spreading over her breasts, fondling them, tweaking her nipples through the thin material of her bra.

“When we can,” she said. “John does travel so very much these days. You’re quite the inquisitive one, aren’t you?”

Jonah smiled and shrugged, and knew he couldn’t push it.

It was only a few floors up. They stepped into a narrow corridor, elegantly furnished in luxurious carpet and wallpaper that probably cost the same as an Eastern European country’s GDP per foot. The redhead’s dress was simply left behind in the elevator.

She beckoned for him to follow, past a few polished oak doors to one at which she stopped. There was no plastic key card for the door—she removed a small gold key from her bra, and slotted it into the keyhole. Old school.

Inside, the suite was large, high-ceilinged. More opulence in furnishings and fittings—more so even than the luxury hotels he'd been to recently.

The bedroom must have been through one of the doors, but they were standing in a large sitting room, where sofas and armchairs offered a substantial social space. You could hold a small drinks party here, Jonah thought.

At the heart of the room, though, where you might expect some kind of table—

even just a coffee table—there was nothing, just space.

“Will you bind me?” the redhead asked, stooping briefly to retrieve a white rope from one of the armchairs around the central space.

She handed the rope to him, and stood there before him, her arm outstretched for him.

He wrapped the rope around her delicate wrists, slowly so that he might get some kind of semblance of a binding that worked, although it came across as erotic, perhaps. Lydia smiled seductively up at him, no doubt anticipating what he was going to be doing with her. Bit her lip.

For Jonah, there were only questions: was she going to let him tie her to a bed somewhere?

Was her husband intending to stay down there with his guests at the dinner table? Or would there be some element of voyeurism, as there had at the last Network event he had been to?

Actually, by luck more than anything, he achieved quite a tidy binding around her wrists, circling the remaining rope around the strands joining her wrists together.

Tied, she lifted her arms, and he stepped up to her, his arms gently enveloping her body, making as though to kiss her—but then stopping at

the last moment.

He put his nose barely an inch from her face and breathed in long and deep.

Smelling her, as she had done with him in the elevator. Her fragrance brought to mind crisp lemons and strawberries, with a faint hint of cigar smoke that likely came from dinner.

She smiled at his teasing of her.

Then she looked up, and following her gaze, Jonah saw the cast iron hook suspended above them from a chain descending from the ceiling.

Jonah might have asked her if she was serious, but he was channelling Robert, his City boy persona. And Robert didn't ask questions. Robert was experienced, world-weary. He knew what a woman like this wanted. He might also do better than Jonah at ignoring the fact that there was a sardonic but beautiful police detective watching all this from his glasses.

He reached up to take the loose end of the rope binding Lydia's wrists up to the hook. He could hear her catch her breath as he fastened the rope to the hook, shackling her in standing position right in the middle of the room.

"What do you want me to do?" he whispered to her, perhaps revealing a weakness in his Robert persona—Jonah showing through the cracks.

The redhead smiled wickedly. She whispered: "Whatever you want to do. Can't you see? I'm all yours now."

He touched his nose to hers, breathing in her sweet, sharp scent once again, but this time he wasn't just teasing. He parted his lips and sucked gently on her bottom lip.

She opened her eyes and smiled at him, then he took her head in his hands and kissed her more forcefully, touching his tongue inside her mouth, making her moan.

His hands dropped to her breasts as he kissed her, squeezing her, coaxing out those cute little moans, his fingers trailing to her little buds, which

were so very hard. Teasing them, crushing them through her transparent bra.

She gasped as he reached up to pull on the rope, stretching her arms up tighter, then fixing her in this new position. She had to stand on tiptoes to achieve it, but though it seemed cruel, Jonah felt certain she wanted it this way. It was a challenge—if she demanded it, he'd loosen her cord.

She was smiling as he kissed her again, as he touched his hands to her pale neck, brushed her cherry-red locks out of her face and over her shoulders.

He trailed one of his hands down over her stomach, over the rough fabric of her suspender belt and down between her legs. She was very, very wet. She groaned as he slipped a finger inside her, gasped as he stirred it within her tight, slippery channel.

Feeling able to take his time, pursue things at his own pace, Jonah stepped back and removed his suit jacket, draping it over a nearby armchair. He could see her chest rising and falling in shallow breaths as the redhead, Lydia, waited for him.

When he returned to her, his fingers were straight back inside her, his palm cupping her mound. She stirred her hips as he fucked her with his hand, her breathing turning into panting.

He took her to the brink—but he did not give her release. Instead, as she appeared to be nearing a first orgasm of the evening, he took his hands away, stepped back again.

She strained at her bonds, pushing her body forward, reaching for him.

But he stepped back, admiring her, teasing her. Slowly unfastened his tie, and set it down on his jacket. He took a deep breath close to her face, and he swore he could already detect the hint of her arousal in the air. But when she reached for a kiss, again he stepped back.

He slowly unbuttoned his shirt, then peeled it off.

Now he kissed her, and she melted into his kiss, desperate for his touch.



They heard voices in the corridor outside the room, and Jonah made the assumption that it was simply other hotel guests on the way to their rooms. But he saw Lydia blush deeply red, and he caught the immediate sense that his initial assumption was wildly incorrect.

Had the husband come up to watch?

They heard the key turn in the lock, and Jonah was a little shocked as the door opened to see that it wasn't the husband—or at least, not only the husband. A stream of people, every single one of the guests from that dinner table, came into the room.

Most of them were carrying glasses of wine or brandy, one or two of the men bearing cigars.

None of them seemed surprised to find the host's wife trussed up like this, shackled to a hook hanging from the ceiling, the young man stripped to the waist and holding her, kissing her. They seemed to take it in their stride as they found seats on the sofas and in the armchairs surrounding that little arena.

They were even holding quiet conversation while they took in the scene and settled down to watch.

Lydia's husband was the last to enter the room, closing the door behind them all, taking up a little wooden chair from the small table in the corner of the room, to sit down as though head of the table.

Jonah found himself unable to resist looking at the husband, trying to suss him out. Who was he? He had an air of importance about him, that was probably

something to do with his wealth—this hotel or club signified some sort of status, at the least. The man looked Jonah in the eye and smiled coolly, giving him a nod of acknowledgement, or perhaps of consent.

Beautiful, isn't she? The husband's expression said to him. Enjoy her, please, with my blessing.

Lydia was blushing ferociously now—not helped by her complexion—at her absolute exposure in front of her friends and dinner guests. She looked into Jonah's eyes, her own pale blue eyes silently pleading with

him to continue, as though she believe if he only continued to ravage her, her humiliation would be reduced in the eyes of all those in attendance.

He kissed her mouth, but then as she was getting back into it, moaning at the tenderness of his lips and tongue on hers, he dropped down slowly, trailing his face down over her breasts and her stomach, until he was kneeling there between her thighs, looking up at her pale, hairless mound, and the little glistening slit beneath.

Lydia caught her breath again as he leaned forward, the spicy scent of her arousal thick in the air as he opened his mouth to spread his lips over the apex of her pussy. It was only as he began to taste her that he realized it hadn't been her catching her breath—it had been Mulray, watching from afar.

She'd been silent so long that he'd almost forgotten she was there. But now it tweaked his sense of mischief that she was watching all this. Maybe it wasn't a bad thing. He found that he wanted to try to shock her, and maybe excite her.

He was surprised to find that the redhead tasted sweet, artificially so. He traced his tongue gently between her lips, and the familiar female flavor was almost completely hidden by it. Some kind of cream or lubricant? Jonah even wondered if she'd been playing with some kind of sex toy made of candy, or if she'd been toying at her pussy with a lollipop before dinner.

Was it a lack of confidence on her part? She wanted to make sure whoever her suitor was for the evening, that he would want to go down on her, that their guests would be able to watch such a thing.

It wasn't unpleasant, perhaps it was even a little fun for a change.

But as he slid two fingers inside her, tonguing and sucking gently on her clit, he wanted to sample the woman beneath the sweetness.

Despite the audience, Lydia seemed able to focus on the pleasure he was giving her. Her eyes closed, her breathing became irregular, deep sighs spiked by gasps and whimpering cries.

Jonah found himself sneaking surreptitious glances at some of the guests sitting around them, watching. They all seemed quite refined, and though

they were definitely fascinated by what was going on, and riveted on Lydia and her responses, they continued to converse amongst themselves, as though they were sitting around a fashion catwalk rather than in an intimate hotel room a few feet away from one of their friends having sex with a stranger.

The redhead seemed to go weak at the knees as he continued to vibrate his tongue against her clit, and occasionally dip it inside her wet slit. His fingers buried inside her only made her weaker still, until she was supported more by the hook and her rope binding than her tiptoes.

When her orgasm came, it was perhaps only a minor one, a foothill on the way to her grander peaks, but she was virtually hanging off her hook, thrashing about.

After it, she seemed like some kind of helpless damsel in distress hanging there.

Jonah could turn her around with a single finger, probably could have spun her round and round like a bauble on a Christmas tree.

The husband was sitting there looking up at her, and as she now faced him, he smiled at her, nodded appreciatively. He was the only member of the audience not chatting with others. He was more focused, and Jonah could see the bulge between his thighs that spoke of his real enjoyment of his wife's infidelity.

Jonah stood, and Lydia was rocking gently back and forth on the hook as she recovered her breath, offering her behind to him.

He felt odd to be removing his pants in front of an audience—but he knew it was expected. It was no worse than knowing Mulray was watching, and he had gotten used to that idea a little more now. There was even something mildly thrilling at knowing he was exposing himself to these people, and perhaps more so that they would be watching him fucking this woman, their friend and dinner

companion.

Naked, he stepped up behind her, his hard cock pointing like a rapier.

He placed his hand over her hip and the suspender belt holding up her stockings, his cock sliding between her thighs. He heard her sigh as he touched his sensitive tip to the heat of her sex, stroked it around her slippery folds.

Then she moaned quietly as he edged forward and slid his hardness inside her tight channel.

As he began thrusting into her, he was able to reach around her, one hand gliding over her smooth mound to seek out her clit, pressing against it as he fucked her.

She sighed, "Oh God... Oh yes..."

Yet as his thrusting accelerated, and her moans and cries became more plaintive, more breathless, he put both his hands on the pleasing roundness of her behind to focus on his pounding into her.

Would she come again this quickly?

He pulled her tightly into him as her panting became heavily labored, her hips swaying to boost the friction between them. He was holding her by the throat, but she didn't seem to mind, taking it further and further until she was shuddering against him, all her weight pressing down on that hook.

Jonah stepped away, amused that she had come apparently so easily, so quickly.

The husband looked from his wife to Jonah, and his nod was a surprised salute, that this stranger could make his wife feel so good.

Lydia turned to face him again, fire in her eyes. She was no longer concerned about the people watching them, it seemed. Didn't care that her flushed, soaking pussy was on display to everyone, to people who had politely sat with her around a dinner table all evening, taking care to mind their table manners and use the right cutlery to partake of the appropriate course.

She gyrated her hips, offering him a lewd enticement to come back and get her.

Jonah stepped back up, breathing her in again, and stroked his hardness around

her mound and between her legs, grazing it against the soft flesh of her inner thighs and around her pussy.

Then he was inside her again, and she was beaming at him, biting her lip, loving it that she was so wicked, so depraved.

He pushed up her bra, his hands containing her bare breasts, squeezing her velvet flesh, flicking over those impossibly hard nipples as he pumped his well-lubricated shaft inside her.

He kissed her neck, inhaling her warm scent of lemon and strawberry. He kissed her mouth briefly, though she broke away to gasp for air.

This time, he felt the big one coming. The earthquake rather than the warning tremors. Well, she would only be able to take so much hanging from that hook.

Jonah allowed himself to go with it, holding her tightly around the waist as he continued driving into her, nudging his face into the top of her neck, into her coppery hair, putting all his effort into the constriction of his hips, pulsing as he slammed into her.

Her cries almost seemed to be suffering, except that her mouth was stretched wide in a broad smile.

He was groaning himself as he felt himself passing the point of no return.

Then he was wrapping his arms around her tighter still, his cheek locked against hers, and as the husband and their dinner guests looked on, Jonah let himself go, his cock throbbing as he pumped his cream deep within her.

And as he came inside her, so very publicly, Lydia was shuddering and shaking in her most powerful climax yet.

He kissed her, and she was smiling like some innocent who had never expected him to be so naughty with her. But she kissed him back, with some affection, as though it might tease her husband for doing this to her.

“Bravo,” came the familiar voice in his ear. Mulray. “She looks like another satisfied customer.”

Was she a touch out of breath as she spoke in his ear, or was that his imagination? Jonah felt the blood being pumped into his manhood again at the thought that the Detective had been watching everything. The fact she’d always been off limits to him only made her more desirable. But it was probably why Emma felt so confident asking her to step in to monitor him on this encounter.

“We’ll have to check the faces of those people in the audience, see if we can determine who any of them are,” Mulray said, apparently trying to get back to business, to distract from the fact that she’d just watched him having sex.

The husband was holding his clothes as Jonah stepped away from Lydia. The man seemed very pleased with himself. He said to Jonah: “Thank you. I’ll show you where you can change.”

Jonah shared a last look with Lydia, and then followed the husband to a door in the wall behind, which led to a bathroom.

In the bathroom, standing up on the counter, was a little white card. It was blank except for three printed letters: ACF.

“Well, well, well, wasn’t that interesting?” said Mulray.

## **Two**

Detective Mulray was still parked out on the street as he emerged from the building. As he approached her little dark blue Ford, she wound down her window.

“Get in.”

It surprised him a little that she’d stuck around, though she was beginning to make a habit of driving him around town. Something about her status as a police officer made him instinctively believe she would disapprove of the kinds of things he was doing on his No Strings dates—and this time, she had witnessed everything.

But Mulray was no ordinary police officer. She'd set him up with Lily Foster knowing that something more than just a passing friendship might occur.

"So what happens now?" he asked, breaking the ice as Mulray handed him what she'd been holding—a notepad and Emma's iPad among other things—so that he could hold it while she drove. "You drop me off, then go report back to Emma?"

"She wants to know you're safe."

He nodded. Felt a prickle of what felt like jealousy. Mulray was going to go see Emma, while he wasn't allowed to. "You've gotten quite close, you two, haven't you?" he said, not really meaning to say it out loud.

"What makes you say that?"

"I used to think you guys were following me. I mean, someone was following me—but it wasn't the police, was it? Yet you always seem to know where I am, where I'm going to be."

Her hands on the wheel as they pulled away from the curb, Mulray shrugged.

"You're not a very complicated guy, Jonah. I've said it before."

"But you don't have time to tour all my standard haunts every time you want to track me down. And that time you picked me up on The Strand, coming out of King's College. I've only ever been there a couple of times. But she told you I was there, didn't she? She's your mole."

Mulray didn't deny anything. "I never even asked you what you were doing there," she said. "Thought you were an Oxford man."

"I'm going to change my PhD subject."

"Only place that would have you?"

"Something like that. It's actually my best option for switching to sociology."

"Sociology?"

“My interest has changed, I suppose,” he said. “I’m more interested in studying people now, not wildlife.”

Mulray nodded, and he could see in her eyes she understood why he was a changed man. As they crossed the King’s Road heading south toward the river, she said, “It’s a good thing, Jonah. It means you’re looking beyond all this now.”

“Beyond all this?”

“When I first met you, you had this sense of... recklessness... about you. I’d say you were almost suicidal in your desperation to confront Nate’s killer. I think perhaps if you’d had better chances of actually tracking her down back then, I’d have been worried about you.”

“Thanks.”

“But you’re looking ahead now, to the future. That’s good, isn’t it?”

“I think so,” he said.

“It’s Emma, right? She’s changed your outlook.” Mulray looked at him briefly, and he felt a burning sensation as her large brown eyes briefly focused on him.

Jonah nodded, then sighed a little louder than he meant to in the detective’s

presence. Well, Mulray might have seen him naked now, but there was no hiding how he really felt about Emma.

He said, “She probably doesn’t even want me now, huh?”

“Sure she does. She’s just a little freaked out by it all.”

“Freaked out?”

Mulray smiled, “She’s a little young for heavy life decisions—but you’ve got her making one.”

“I didn’t ask her to marry me.”



“You didn’t. But you know, for someone like her, at that stage in her life, it’s almost like marriage to think about settling with one guy.”

“I didn’t ask her to do that, either,” he said, but deep down he felt the conflicted feelings of wanting her to remain only his, while being secretly excited by the idea of her being unrestricted by monogamy.

“Well, you’ve given her a lot to think about. I’m sure she’ll get her head around it some time soon.”

Mulray’s suggestion made his heart leap a little. And it did sound as though she’d spoken to Emma about it.

The detective changed the subject, feeling the need to take some of the tension out of the air as they turned left onto the Chelsea Embankment to drive east along the River Thames. She said, “So Oxford not tempting you back? It’s so beautiful there...”

“I don’t know—I had a great time there, but it’s my old life. I went back there a few times after Nate died, and everywhere I looked it was like remembering how things used to be.”

“You feel like you just need to move on.”

“I think it’s the only way I’ll cope.”

“Sociology. So you can just change your PhD subject straight to something else?”

“Thought you were doing something about climate change and birds.”

He nodded, playing down how impressed he was at her remembering his PhD

subject. “I’ve decided on a fresh start,” he said. “A degree in sociology and criminology.”

“Criminology?” she raised an eyebrow at that.

He shrugged. “The Professor’s suggestion, actually. Professor Knighton—he’s the head of the sociology department at King’s College London. I guess we were talking a lot about the investigation...”

“He have any interesting insights?”

“He asked if Julian Foster’s murder might have been an accident, some kind of erotic asphyxiation thing gone wrong.”

Mulray nodded, and glanced behind her before passing a slow vehicle. “It was considered at the time,” she said. “The evidence that the killer cleaned everything up so well suggested it was a more calculated murder, but there was a line of inquiry that she or he simply cleaned up and got out of there to avoid any legal trouble.”

“The Professor said the killer might have developed a taste for murder—for the power involved in ending someone’s life.”

“It’s possible. Probable, if she’s a true serial killer. But I thought you were getting more interested in the whole conspiracy angle recently. What with that wife-sharing network you’re getting into. The Network—isn’t that what your redhead wife called it?”

“Uh-huh.” He sighed, “Maybe it is just a coincidence, but more and more it looks as though it did connect all of the victims. I don’t know—I don’t know enough about it yet. Maybe Julian Foster found out about the Network from Lord Moss, and decided to write about it in his next book. So they were both bumped off. Then Nate and the others... I don’t know. They broke the rules or something. But maybe the killer was just part of the Network, and found her victims that way.”

“I suppose there’s no point in me telling you to be careful. If you don’t know who or what runs this Network...”

“I know, I know. It’s risky. But I want to know. And if I have someone to watch over my shoulder...”

Mulray caught the tone of his voice, and said: “She’ll come back to you soon enough, you know that, right? Once she figures you’ve suffered enough.”

He nodded.

“And if you ask me, she’ll be thrilled you’re talking about staying in London, not going back to Oxford.”

“I hope so.”

“You just have to give her time to sort herself out. She’s not really angry at you.”

“Really? Because it sure as Hell seems like it.”

Mulray focused for a few moments on getting through the awkward junction at Tower Hill, then said: “She needs to get it out of her system before she makes her mind up about you.”

““Get it out of her system’?”

The detective shrugged, “I’m fairly sure of it. Right now she’s starting to see a few of the guys on that list you pulled off Julian Foster’s account—the guys Foster was messaging about interviews for his book.”

“She’s dating them?” Jonah felt as though someone had poured hot lead into his stomach.

“Their wives, I believe. Since they’re mostly about the wife-sharing, it seems.”

Mulray flashed her eyes at him, taunting him about how wicked Emma was, or perhaps trying to provoke him into outrage at Emma’s bisexuality. He wasn’t outraged, only aroused. And heart-broken.

“But she is going out with them? Not just messaging them?”

The detective said, “I’m not saying for certain anything will happen. And she’s only doing what you’ve been doing...”

“And she was worried about my safety? How the Hell am I supposed to feel about her seeing a bunch of strangers? And since the killer is female...”

Jonah felt it hard to breathe. Yet while he was horrified at Emma putting herself at risk, underneath it all, there was something strangely exciting about her confirming herself as a wildcat.

“Perhaps you’ll have to talk to her about watching her dates.”

He felt his manhood thickening further inside his pants at that idea—so much so he had to shuffle in his seat to get comfortable.

“And once she’s got all this out of her system?” he asked Mulray. “What then?”

“Either she’ll feel she’s sewn enough of her wild oats to settle down with you—”

“Or?”

Mulray smiled and gave him a wicked, knowing glance. “Or you guys will figure out that your relationship doesn’t have to preclude her from going on sewing her wild oats...”

Jonah felt a slight sense of panic at the idea that he might love someone like Emma while agreeing to her non-monogamy. At the same time, he was so hard at the thought of sharing a wildly unorthodox sexual journey with her, it overcame the discomfort he attributed at least in part to the social norms ingrained within him.

With a sigh, he tried to change the subject outright. Mulray might have already seen him naked, but he could do without her catching sight of his erection pressing through his pants if she happened to glance down at any point.



It was nice to be given a lift home after a tiring evening. Almost made up for the slight awkwardness that now existed in that little car, from the fact that the police detective had just watched him having sex.

He tried to relax, and avoid thinking about it, but it was difficult not to.

On the one hand, Mulray was a very attractive woman, and to know that she had that strange, intimate connection with him quietly reawakened his dormant desire for her—and that made him feel guilty enough considering his feelings for Emma.

On the other hand, they had built up a carefully professional relationship through this investigation, with both respecting and appreciating the other's contribution to the case, and this evening had blown that completely off course, on an unknown heading.

When they arrived on West India Quay, Jonah asked her politely if she'd like a coffee before heading off on her merry way, and he was at least half hoping she'd decline so that he could just go upstairs and crash.

But she said, "Sure, I could do with something to keep me awake a little longer."

In the elevator up to the 22 nd floor, he noticed that the top few buttons of her shirt were unfastened again, offering him a view through the mirrored walls that included a hint of her white lacy bra. It hadn't been something he'd spotted in the car, since he'd been avoiding looking at her because of the tension he felt between them.

This was not the way he imagined Detective Inspector Mulray around the office at Scotland Yard. She was giving him a less-than-subtle reminder of her femininity.

"This Network—you think it's an actual organization?" she was asking him, her tone professional, her eyes giving him no clues about why her shirt buttons seemed so very unreliable around him. "I mean, it probably doesn't have some kind of head office somewhere, but is there someone who runs it? Who leads it?"

"I don't know enough about it yet. So far it just seems like a loose arrangement

of like-minded people," Jonah said. "Fairly affluent types, people with ties to the City—who like a little fun with their wives beyond the normal kind of thing."

"Swinging, basically."

He shrugged, "Basically. But it's not just couples swapping partners. It seems more focused on the wives—and the wives' sexual pleasures. The husbands take a more voyeuristic role."

All the way up, Jonah had made sure she wouldn't catch him staring at her chest, but as he mentioned the word "voyeuristic", his subconscious drew his eye straight to the fancy white lace that seemed so out of character for a woman who tried to downplay her sexuality to fit in with the male-dominated world of Scotland Yard.

She caught him, of course, and he blushed then turned quickly away. Before he did, he noticed her mouth squeeze into a slight smile.

"So how many of your... dates... have involved this Network, so far?" she asked as the elevator came to a halt.

He led them out into the hallway, saying: "I'm not entirely sure. Some of them were obviously part of it—tonight, for instance. Then I think there was a woman called Gemma, and there was Victoria, she was definitely part of it."

"Any others?"

He paused briefly before tapping out the code on the electronic lock for the front door to the apartment. "I'm not sure," he said. "I think so. There was a woman named Gabriella—I met her at the Savoy. She was probably wealthy enough.

Other than her... I'm not so sure."

He took her coat and hung it on the coat stand inside the door, then went straight for the kitchen to fetch Mulray's coffee, hoping she wasn't intending to stay long.

"And you got to the Network through that list of dates on your brother's website profile?" she asked him. "That was when it began?"

"That was when I thought it began," he said. "But it feels as though I've just

been heading toward it, almost like it's an inevitable thing."

Mulray dropped her notepad and papers on the corner of the island separating the kitchen from the rest of the apartment as she watched him firing up the coffee machine.

“And it’s only recently they’ve started handing you those little cards with black letters printed on them?”

“Yes, only recently. Last couple of evenings.”

“You don’t have any idea what those are about?”

Mulray fished the card he’d been given that evening from her pile on the kitchen counter.

“Shares, I think. Or at least the codes for shares. I talked to my friend in the City

—Graham—about it, and he thought that’s what they were.”

The coffee machine gurgled as it made the detective’s drink.

“So what are we to think of that?” she said, perching on the back of the nearest sofa. “There are other Network... evenings... going on, aren’t there? While you’re out there seeing to someone’s wife?”

Jonah turned, “You’ve got to suppose so. Any number of wives could be out there having an evening of fun with a younger man each night. They just set up their dates through that website, and there you go.”

“So suppose those little cards are given out to all the traders who are out playing with the wives on a given night, or during a particular week, perhaps...”

Jonah nodded. “It’s what Graham thought. They get back to the office and start discreetly buying those particular shares.”

“And with all of them across the Network buying the same company...”

“The share price goes up.” Jonah handed the coffee mug to her.

She breathed in the aroma, then took a sip. “Good coffee.”

“My brother had good taste.”

“Runs in the family,” she said, and he couldn’t quite get her insinuation. Mulray looked at him, said, “Would there be enough people involved in

this Network to actually push the share price up?”

“I don’t know. Maybe. Seems like a convoluted way to fix the stock market, though. Setting up a whole network of people sharing their wives.”

“Hard to trace any of it, hard to get anyone involved to go on record about it.

They’re either handing over their wives to other men, or they’re sleeping with the wives of other men.”

“Or they’re the wives,” Jonah smiled.

Mulray nodded, “You get vetted on the pretext that nobody wants word of the wife-sharing to get out in public, but really it’s your ability to trade that’s the important thing.”

“I’m not entirely sure how I got through the vetting process, to be honest,” Jonah said. “I mean, I’m pretty sure it’s people from the Network who must have been watching me—but I’m hardly much of a City trader in real life.”

Mulray said, “They saw you meeting Graham, talking to people from Nate’s company?”

“It’s possible. But that would hardly allow me to pass even a basic identity check.”

“It can’t be that they’re just a little incompetent when it comes to the security checks?” the detective suggested, finishing up her coffee in record time, much to Jonah’s relief.

“Can’t believe they would be.”

“Are they hoping you’ll stop your part in this investigation?”

“What, distracted by all the hot married women I could have as a member?” he laughed. “Seems like a long shot.”

“Well,” said Mulray as he helped her with her coat, and showed her to the door.



“I guess you need your rest.”

“Say hello to Emma for me,” he said, trying to keep his cool about it all, to stop himself from theorizing about just how close Emma was with Mulray, and what any of it meant for her relationship with him.

“I will. But don’t worry, Jonah. I swear, you’ll get her back in good time.”

“I hope so,” he sighed.

It was only in the morning, after a desperately-needed sleep, that Jonah found that Mulray had left her little pile of papers—and Emma’s iPad—behind on the kitchen counter when she’d left the apartment.

He fired off a text message to alert the detective to her loss, but then standing there in his boxer shorts as the coffee machine gurgled in the production of his early morning pick-me-up, he found himself curious about what Mulray had recorded the previous night—what Emma would get to see of his date with Lydia.

Then, when he fired up the iPad and flicked through to the video app, assuming that would be where the video file for the previous evening’s date would be stored, he found something a little unexpected sitting there alongside it.

It was labelled “Emma and Clement”, and when he clicked on it, the video footage revealed Emma going into someone’s apartment.

When Clement, the friend of murder victim Martin Sallow and one of Emma’s previous dates, turned up showing her around his lavish bachelor pad, Jonah found himself burning up inside.

Was this really a video of Emma’s night with Clement? And could he handle watching it if it was?

### **Three**

Had Mulray been monitoring Emma’s night with Clement, or had Emma simply been recording herself?

If Emma was resolved to date other men with possible links to the Hotel Killings, and if she wouldn’t accept him monitoring her, perhaps he could

insist on Mulray making absolute certain of her safety. That would make him feel better about her intent to sew her wild oats.

Jonah made himself comfortable in bed with the iPad, resolved to at least attempt to watch the video.

Deep down, he did want Emma to have fun with other men—there was excitement for him in that idea. If he wanted to try it, he couldn't flinch from the reality of it. If he had the opportunity, he had to at least try to watch. Perhaps he'd like it. Plenty of men, judging from those Network evenings, did enjoy watching their wives playing with other men.

Was her camera in her glasses? If so, she'd taken them off. The video was looking at her side-on, not from her own point of view as if she were wearing the camera. Jonah wondered if she'd found some other fancy gadget online to add to her increasingly spy-like repertoire.

She was lounging lengthways on a big, comfortable looking cream sofa, leaning up against the armrest, her black sequined dress riding up to show a lot of leg.

God, she looked good. Jonah felt his heartstrings pulled by her beauty.

She was gently stroking her thigh as she looked up at Clement, who was out of shot. She seemed so relaxed, so comfortable in the other man's presence, it crushed Jonah's heart.

Clement stepped into shot, and as he perched on the sofa by her feet, Jonah saw that he was stripped to the waist, and the white trousers he initially thought the

guy was wearing turned out to be a towel.

"I still think you should have taken her details. Sent her the dry-cleaning bill,"

Emma said, halfway through a conversation.

Clement was really buff, the definition of his abs impressive. He leaned back and took one of her feet in his hands to massage it.

“You know how long it would have taken to sort that out?” he smiled, flashing big white teeth. “Do you know how much I earn in that kind of time?”

“I suppose...”

He shook his head, “Wouldn’t be worth it. Just buy a new suit, buy a new shirt.”

Flashy. Jonah felt his insides burning with jealousy. How did he compare to Clement? He didn’t even have a job. He was going back to school to get into sociology and criminology. He could see in Emma’s eyes—thanks to the high definition camera—how impressed she was with this guy.

Clement started softly kissing the arch of her foot, holding it in both hands as he gazed up at her in unconcealed lust with those deep brown eyes. Her pale skin contrasted beautifully with his caramel tone, and the aesthetic appeal of the two together also made Jonah’s insides burn.

Jesus, the guy’s hand was drifting up Emma’s leg now—this was Emma, Jonah’s Emma.

Yet despite the jealousy, the hurt, this was strangely thrilling to Jonah in ways he could not have fully expected or appreciated before. He was watching his exquisite girlfriend—if that was what she was—seducing another man, or allowing herself to be seduced by another man. And it was undeniably beautiful, unavoidably exciting to behold.

“You have great legs, you know that?” Clement said.

He made Jonah suddenly doubt whether he had ever paid Emma enough complements during their dating. Clement caressed her calves and her thighs, and her foot was touching down on his crotch, feeling out what was there under that loose towel.

Clement slipped open the towel, revealing a startlingly large cock between his toned thighs, onto which he placed Emma’s dainty foot. And only semi-erect from what he could tell. She was offering him a seductive smile as she stroked that enormous member with her foot, and then held it between both her feet, using them to pump his long shaft.

Biting her lip with clear desire as she did so.

“You have a great cock, you know that?”

“It’s all yours,” he grinned.

Emma swung her legs around so that she was sitting next to him on the couch, leaning over him, her hand curling around his large phallus. As she slowly started jacking him, she leaned in for a kiss, sucking on his top lip, trading her tongue for his.

Jonah felt his whole body simmering. He couldn’t stop watching.

He watched her sit up and peel her dress up over her head, leaving herself in nothing but a pair of black thong panties. So stunning, her pert breasts peaked with stiff nipples.

And weirdly, it was such a thrill to see her lean over him, take that big cock in her hand again, and envelope its tip in her mouth. He saw her stroking the thing against her cheeks, her lips, her tongue slipping out to flick around its sensitive head.

It was so obscene, and yet the intense feelings it provoked in Jonah made him harder than ever.

She used her pretty face and her mouth to pleasure him. She pushed upwards on her knees and stroked the tip of his cock around her soft, pale breasts, grazing it around her hard nipples. Enjoying this new cock, indulging in it. Perhaps teasing Jonah, if she had any inkling that she would one day show him this video.

Then she was kissing the man’s mouth again, with tender passion, slipping her tongue between his lips, showing real affection. It punched Jonah in the stomach, more so even than her going down on him.

He held her hair back out of her face as she bobbed down on his pole once again.

She was good, and Jonah took some kind of pleasure in watching how he responded to her, how she made him moan. She was so desirable, and at the end of the day, when she was ready, Jonah would possess her.

Deep down, he still felt sure she was his. She would give this guy up for him. He could never be one hundred percent sure, though. The uncertainty made him feel a little twinge of nausea until he contained it.

Clement ushered her up onto her knees on the couch, and rose to his feet himself, that enormous erection standing between them, which he now stroked over her body, her breasts, her stomach as he stood by her. Rubbing her nipples with his cock, it was so filthy, wicked, depraved, and Emma was loving every moment.

“I have something to confess,” she said. Whatever it was, she seemed comfortable enough with Clement to share it with him. That only tightened the vice around Jonah’s heart.

“Don’t tell me, you used to be a man,” Clement joked. He even made Jonah want to like him.

Emma laughed. Such a sweet sound. “No, but considering what you told me, it might be worse.”

“What is it?”

“I’m married.”

Jonah’s ears pricked up, a white-hot pulse of heat flashing through his chest.

“And that’s your big confession?” Clement held her hair as he kissed her, her head tilted back, submissive, possessed by him.

“Well, you said...”

“I said I wasn’t particularly into married women—not like Martin. I just wouldn’t actively go out there hoping to find somebody’s wife for a night.”

“So you don’t mind...”

“You’re hot, you’re here. It’s nothing to do with me if you have a ring on your finger—”

“I took it off. Thought it would scare you.”

“You married to some kind of mafia guy who’s going to feed me to the fishes?”

“Of course not!”

“Then I’m not scared. If you wanna cheat on your husband...”

She sat astride one of the armrests of the couch, then lay back to allow him to slip off her panties, revealing that sweet, smooth pussy she had shaved especially for him.

“You are cheating on him?”

Emma glanced at the camera, and the way she looked at it, perhaps imagining Jonah one day watching this, suddenly set him at ease. Emma was putting it all on for some reason. She didn’t have some dark skeleton in her closet about a secret marriage.

“In a way.”

“‘In a way’? What’s that supposed to mean?” Clement knelt next to her on the couch, and ran his hands over her body, feeling her, taking pleasure in her smooth skin.

“It means I’m pretty sure he’s okay with it.”

“‘Pretty sure’. Damn, I hope I don’t ever have a wife like you! So he doesn’t know what you’re up to tonight.”

“No. But he will. Probably.”

“Probably. So will I ever get to see you again?”

Emma raised her legs for him, and Jonah gasped as he saw first the man’s fingers, and then his mouth connect with her sweet pussy. She closed her eyes, tilted her head and moaned as he dipped his tongue inside her.

“If you do that you will,” she purred.

No, no, no, Jonah wanted to yell out. He could have sex with her, he could fuck her hard. But this was too tender, too gentle, too sensual. She

was Jonah's girlfriend, this other man wasn't supposed to make her feel like this.

And yet at the same time, it was wonderful to see. To know that she was receiving such pleasure. That she was such a sexual being, that it took more than a single man to satisfy her fully.

Jonah could understand where Julian Foster had been coming from, wanting other men to worship his goddess of a wife. And Lord Moss, assuming that the man did indeed share his blonde wife.

"He's going to let you? After you've told him about it?"

"I think so." She looked into the camera, directly at Jonah it seemed, and he felt a ripple of energy shoot down his spine, his hardness throbbing between his legs.

She really was talking about him. She really had intended for him to watch this video at some point, he was sure of it. It was exciting to think that she had. Had Mulray even left this iPad in his apartment on purpose, for him to find this?

Emma's moans turned to cries as Clement replaced his tongue with his fingers, penetrating her, filling her, manipulating her. She clung to that armrest and gasped as he moved up to kiss her mouth while he thrust his digits inside her.

It had Jonah wondering if he'd ever made her sound like that. He was sure he had, but seemed so different watching like this, more intense.

Clement now rose to his feet again, and Jonah felt his heart pounding, his stomach folding up as the terrifying prospect of that enormous cock approached his girlfriend's exposed pussy.

It was so huge, so obscene.

He rested it against her body, against her pussy lips, and Jonah watched as Emma momentarily looked toward the camera—straight at him—as though silently assuring him she was still thinking of him, and that this wasn't only about her pleasure and the need to get close to Clement for the investigation.

This was for Jonah to explore his curiosity about sharing her, too.

Jonah felt so powerless, and yet somehow that played into his sexual thrill as well. He couldn't stop her. Her sexuality was overwhelmingly in control, she was taking what she wanted. She was gorgeous, sexy, insatiable.

Then she was looking up at Clement again, telling him, "Fuck me."

He gripped her thighs and eased forward, that huge tip nudging up against her sex, and then plunging inside. Another man's bare cock was inside Emma's sweet pussy, stretching her, making her eyes widen and her jaw drop in astonishment.

It made Jonah so hard to watch, to see that great beast stretching her, drawing out whimpering cries. To see the man's powerful body flexing as he thrust into her, rocking her world with each impact.

To see that great thing glistening with her juices each time it withdrew—it made Jonah crazy with lust and jealousy.

It took only moments for her to come on that enormous cock. Jonah could imagine she was so tight around him, every sensitive part of her pussy in contact with him, and perhaps the feeling that he was too big for her, and that he was so different to Jonah, pushing her over the edge so quickly.

As her cries faded into contented and relaxed moans, Clement manhandled her onto all fours on the couch, pushing her up against the armrest so that she could bend over it, hold it as he re-entered her from behind.

She pushed up her behind as he pounded into her, harder than before, her moans louder though not quite so high-pitched. She held the armrest as though it was a life preserver and she was floundering in the water.

She turned her head and opened her eyes, looking at the camera as she was being fucked by this powerful man, and as she looked directly at him again, Jonah felt a strange and unexpected sense of connection with her. She was using Clement for sex, that look said, but her heart remained with Jonah.



Was this how she felt when she'd watched him with Bethany, and with Gemma?

Watching her being mounted by such a chiseled brute, a lion of the world of men, made Jonah feel diminutive, outclassed. He dominated her physically in a way Jonah did not, and you could see her enjoying it.

Yet somehow Jonah could take a deep breath and enjoy the altruistic glow of granting her this experience.

She still wanted him, if Mulray was to be believed. And if Mulray wasn't to be believed, how had the detective simply stepped in to replace her in monitoring his date with Lydia?

Watching her with Clement, Jonah found himself mentally defending his own abilities in bed, reassuring himself that had never failed to pleasure the pretty blonde while they'd been together. And they had an affectionate bond that went beyond the physical lust. Jonah could offer her the warm stability of real love—

and also, potentially, the prospect of occasional excitement in the arms of men like Clement.

She had to still want him.

Emma pulled herself up, and as Clement lay on the couch, she straddled him, squeezed his fulsome manhood back inside her, and began to ride him. An angel on a mighty steed, sitting primly over him, her thighs flexing, her hips gyrating as she took him to full gallop.

She smiled at the guy seductively, but it wasn't love. She was dripping wet from fucking a titan, a muscular, athletic man. Yet he was an object to her, and she to him.

Jonah was so sure of it—he might have hurt her over the misunderstanding with Lily, but she wasn't gone from him. Couldn't be.

That wasn't to say he couldn't still lose her.

The two lovers on that flat little screen now slumped down onto the floor, not even waiting to go find a bed. Emma slid under him, playing with

him, teasing him, sliding his cock into her mouth again briefly, before stretching out on her back, compliant for him.

Jonah watched him kneel between her open thighs, and slide back inside her

rose-red, stretched, soaking pussy. Pumping her with that thing, that great big sex toy of a cock.

He could appreciate Emma's use of him as the well-shaped man lay over her, his ripped chest draped over her delicate feminine form, enveloping her in his arms, kissing her forcefully as his hips squeezed to thrust into her. The jealousy did enhance the overall experience—and it seemed like it only hurt because Jonah didn't get to have her afterwards. It was the uncertainty that hit him hard, the not knowing whether she would decide to return to him.

She held onto Clement, her fingers splayed over his hefty biceps, turned her head to the side to snatch in what breaths she could manage in between the gasps as he pounded into her. Then she was shaking under him, the expression on her face seeming like pain as she shuddered and rocked and cried out through another forceful climax.

As the big man appeared to be nearing his own end, Jonah saw Emma whisper something into his ear, something that made the great man grin broadly.

He knelt up, then lifted a leg over hers, pulling himself up so that he could kneel over her hips, that huge cock in his hands shining with her come. He looked like a Greek God above her, a classical statue come to life, pumping that trunk of a cock over her while she looked up at him with a wicked, mischievous smile.

Jonah watched as his colossal manhood erupted over her breasts, her stomach, strings of white cream even reaching her neck, her face.

Emma was rubbing it into her soft skin, into her breasts and over her stiff nipples, marking herself with his seed, knowing how she was teasing the secret audience she had, stressing to a distant Jonah her enjoyment of this other man.

It only made him want her more, more than he had ever wanted her before.



There was another part to the video, after Clement had come all over Jonah's girlfriend. The scene suddenly shifted to the bedroom, looking over from the bedside table as Clement lay there up against the pillows.

The sheet moved out of the way and suddenly there was Emma, red-faced and glowing with a hint of perspiration, her pretty face nudged up against the huge shaft poking up from between Clement's powerful thighs.

"Martin went for women like you, you know. They did it, and their husbands let them."

"Yeah?" she kissed the tip of his hard cock, ran her tongue down from top to base. Jonah wasn't so keen on the idea that they'd adjourned to the bedroom to continue their sex session through the entire night. Of course, that dark, despicable part of him, deep down, was delighted by the idea.

"He said a lot of wives of City directors go for that sort of thing, too. Thought it would give him a leg-up the career ladder, you know what I mean?"

"Seriously?"

"Used to see him give the occasional knowing wink to senior management now and again, he had no place doing that."

"He knew them from—" Emma looked up at him, surprised.

"I swear, it was all real. People you'd never expect would acknowledge him."

"Right." She sank down on that great cock, prizing out a moan from him.

"That Lord Moss—the guy who got bumped off in the Ritz last year? Saw him nod a silent hello to Martin once, after a conference."

“Politicians do that all the time,” she said, breathless, then resumed her sucking on his hardness.

“No, this wasn’t the usual making up friends in the audience type of thing. They knew each other. And he was a government minister!”

Watching the iPad, Jonah decided it was high time he went back for another chat with Lady Moss. Perhaps without a police escort this time. What with Julian’s book being on one of her bookshelves, and this idea that Lord Moss was somehow involved in this wife-sharing network in some way. Well, he was a significant investor in the No Strings website, which as far as Jonah understood, the Network was using to coordinate evening events. But Lord Moss wouldn’t know somebody like Martin Sallow unless they were both active participants in the Network.

Emma shifted up, and now the screen showed the lower part of her body as she straddled Clement, as she held his cock beneath her and impaled herself on it.

“You weren’t persuaded to get involved in all that yourself? When you saw who Martin was friendly with?” she asked.

Clement shrugged, “I guess I would have got a bigger bonus. But it just seemed a little weird to me, right? Too good to be true. Like when he talked about it, his eyes seemed to glaze over like he was talking about a cult.”

Then Emma was bouncing on Clement too hard and too fast for any kind of conversation to take place. Jonah watched, but while he was thinking about how he wished he could reclaim her right now, he was also thinking about how best to approach Lady Moss to ask for more information about this shadowy Network.

How would he tell her there was sufficient evidence around to persuade him that she was an active member of the Network?

How would he break it to her that he knew she had probably slept around, probably with her husband’s approval?

Somehow, he just had to get there and do it. Lay it out that he wasn’t going to the police with this, if only she would explain.

## Four

It was barely autumn, and the sun had plummeted from the sky already. It felt depressing to Jonah. It also made him feel he had come out to Chiswick too late, perhaps. Approaching Lady Moss for some kind of off-the-record chat, away from the prying eyes of Scotland Yard, he should have come while it was still light. It might feel threatening to her, this way.

It might also prove threatening to him, of course, if she was somehow part of the Network, part of the whole mystery surrounding the Hotel Killings.

The street was almost empty, with just a few commuters wandering home from work along the tree-lined sidewalk. With a dark blue shirt, gray jacket and dark tan chinos, his smart casual look almost leant him the air of a commuter, perhaps from a start-up tech company—it meant he didn't feel too out of place, if there were people watching out of their windows. And there might well have been people watching out of their windows—one of them had talked to the reporter, Keeley.

But what did he have to hide? He was simply following up on an unanswered question, hoping to talk to another next of kin, to see if they might both bring something more to the table for the police hunting down a suspect.

He felt unauthorized, though. Turning in to Lady Moss's short driveway, knowing he was here without informing Detective Mulray. But if Douglas Moss's widow felt unable to open up in Mulray's presence, Jonah felt the only hope was to talk to her without the police breathing down his neck.

There were no lights on in the house. Jonah stepped into the welcoming light of the small porch, and up to the large front door to press the bell. It rang out somewhere deep inside the building.

A pause, and he noticed his breath was turning to steam in the crisp air.

No sign of life within the house, no response to the doorbell.

So frustrating, that she might not be in. But he hadn't wanted to call ahead, he'd wanted to catch her in, so she couldn't avoid him. And his understanding had been that she rarely went out these days, she had shut

herself in her own little world in this house. Not even visiting the estate up in Hertfordshire or Herefordshire or wherever the hell her husband's stately pile was located.

Jonah drew his jacket a little tighter around his body, beginning to feel the cold a little more now he was no longer moving. Should he wait? Come back later?

Even if she was home later that evening, the later it got the less appropriate his visit would appear.

He took a couple of paces over toward the large bay window, and leaned up against the glass, shielding his view from the reflected streetlight with his hands.

The Mosses had a very elegant home, even with the limited light that came through from the kitchen at the rear—the light kept on, no doubt, to persuade potential burglars that someone was home.

There seemed nothing untoward in what he saw. What had he been expecting? A bloody dagger carelessly left on a coffee table somewhere?

He smiled to himself. Perhaps a case-closing clue would be in the realms of fantasy, but he hoped for another little hint that Lady Moss had been hiding something, like her involvement in wife-sharing activities, and maybe even the Network itself.

He stepped back, scanning the driveway, in need of at least some kind of clue as to whether Lady Moss might be out for an hour, the whole evening, the weekend or the rest of the month. He saw nothing to that effect, but what he did see was an open door leading around the house to the back of the property.

It made him catch his breath. Did he really dare venture back there?

They would have some kind of burglar alarm, they had to considering the value of their possessions. Jonah swallowed, and glanced out onto the street. There was no sign anyone in the house opposite was watching. The curtains were drawn.

He slipped quietly into a shady corner of the front garden, nearest the open door itself, still watching. No sign of any particular danger. A young

man in a suit walked by on the sidewalk, but he was just another commuter on his way home.

Not looking anywhere but straight ahead.

If he was caught, he'd simply say he was trying to find some way to leave a message for Lady Moss, for her eyes only. A stupid excuse, but at least something he could hold onto as he took a deep breath and darted through the open door into the tiny dark passage that ran between the outer wall of the house and the wooden fence bordering the property. At the end of the day, if he was caught he'd have to face the music. He might get some help from Detective Mulray, but couldn't count on it.

Jonah needed to find out more about Lady Moss and what happened to her husband. He felt so strongly about it, he was willing to stretch the rules a little.

He slipped quietly in through the gateway.



His heart was pounding in his ears all the way down that long dark alleyway at the side of the house. Thankfully the high fence around the property kept Jonah safely in the shadows as he proceeded through to a back garden. The building stretched back a fair way—an impressive size, particularly for this part of London. It spoke of the Moss's wealth.

The sound of a police siren far off—but apparently coming closer—stopped him dead in his tracks there in the darkness. Had he set off one of those silent alarms?

A moment later, the siren faded again, and he was on his way.

The back garden that was perhaps as extensive as the house itself. In front of the conservatory was a large patio complete with built-in grill. Good for a party—

one of the Moss's impressive dinner parties, perhaps Jonah recalled the photos that had been on the wall of the upstairs hallway the last time he'd been here, in the company of Detective Mulray. Beyond the patio was an

impeccable lawn, then trees. He almost expected to see a swimming pool, but the Moss's largesse did not stretch quite that far.

He ventured slowly past the conservatory, one step at a time, ready to flee at any hint that he triggered an alarm.

The adrenaline buzz kept him going, perhaps further than he would have dared otherwise. He felt a touch foolish, not quite knowing what he was doing. He peered in through the conservatory windows, through thriving pot plants that were undoubtedly maintained by Reynolds, the Moss's dutiful butler. Toys spread out on the floor suggested that the Moss's son, Christopher, had been there recently.

By Lady Moss's wicker chair there was a small table, and a couple of paperback novels. They looked like regular airport thrillers, nothing particularly revealing.

In fact, the whole place was rather disappointing to Jonah. He took a few steps back, turned to glance at the garden. The perfect slabs of imported stone laid up to the immaculate lawn and its snooker-table velvet grass.

What was he expecting, slight mounds under which bodies might be buried?

Jesus.

But Lady Moss did present an interesting suspect. Unlike random prostitutes dragged up by the police to distract the national press from their unsuccessful attempts to find the killer, Lady Moss had a powerful motive, at least to despatch her husband. Money. Lots and lots of it.

But then why kill all the other victims? Julian Foster might have seen something, or heard something when he'd interviewed Lord Moss for his book. Lord Moss might have told him something, suggested some kind of fear of his wife.

And Nate? Martin Sallow? Oliver Pearson? Kelvin Selmer? Why would she need to kill them?

Jonah wandered back to the conservatory, uttering a sigh of frustration as he put a hand on the glass of the door into the house ostensibly to aid him in peering inside it.



The door swung slowly open.

Jesus.

He could just step inside Lady Moss's house. So easy. But then he really would be breaking the law, no question. Breaking and entering. But if Lady Moss turned out to be a serial killer, it would be like he had the moral high ground, breaking into her house.

Was there any kind of alarm? If you were the type to set an alarm, would you be the type that also failed to lock the door from the conservatory out to the garden?

He took a deep breath, and stepped over the threshold.

For a moment, nothing. He relaxed. No alarm, no security doors slamming down to catch him in an inescapable cage, no spikes jabbing up from the floor. No police siren in the distance.

But then, from behind him, a sudden voice made him nearly jump out of his skin.

“What the hell are you up to?”

His instant reaction was to run—except that the voice was too close behind him.

If it was a policeman, a security guy, he would be chased down and busted in seconds.

Only it wasn't a policeman, wasn't a security guy. Jonah turned to find Harold Keeley, the newspaper reporter, standing behind him.

“You,” he said in a loud whisper. “You scared the crap out of me!”

The ginger-haired Guardian man hissed, “Are you insane? You can't just go walking straight into her house!”

“I didn't entirely mean to. The door was open.”

“Right.”

“No alarms.”

“That you can hear. You know there’s a police station just around the corner from here?” Keeley took a step forward, into the conservatory. Against his own apparent objection to Jonah’s strategy. “And come to think of it, you know MI5

is currently sitting out in a gray Range Rover in front of the house, watching this place?”

“They didn’t do a great job stopping me from walking in, huh?”

Keeley smiled, “No, they didn’t—” then his face turned serious. “In fact, there’s something very odd about that, don’t you think?”

“So they’re not here to protect Lady Moss at all?”

“Or they don’t think you’re a threat.”

They stood for a moment, frozen. Not quite knowing what to do with their suspicion that the British secret service might have let Jonah break in to Lady Moss’s abode.

“So what are you doing here, then?” Jonah asked the reporter, moving to close the conservatory door behind him.

“I was with my contact across the street. She told me there were strange men coming and going from Lady Moss’s house at night. So I’ve been watching, you know, every now and then.”

“And? Have there been strange men coming and going?” asked Jonah as he scouted around the conservatory.

“Uh-huh. And staying until morning, too,” Keeley said. The reporter was glancing out of the windows on the side of the conservatory, concerned someone might be coming out from the alleyway. “I guess now the husband’s gone, she’s free to play. Maybe old James Bond out there in the Range Rover’s been told not to interfere. Hence you were able to get in here unchallenged.”

“And you?”

“I came in the back way—from Duke Road. Had to come through a couple of other gardens, not easy.”

Jonah ducked his head through the doorway into the kitchen, into the main part of the house. Again, no alarms sounded, and nothing happened as he tentatively stepped into the kitchen.

He scanned the kitchen, but there was really nothing much of interest. The place was well-ordered, tidy, with nothing out of place.

Keeley stepped into the kitchen, apparently satisfied enough that nobody was actively coming after them. “So what brought you here?” he asked Jonah. “You got something on her? Lady Moss?”

Jonah shrugged, “I just wanted to talk to her. I didn’t want the police to know I was here, so maybe she’d open up. Didn’t have her number, so... well, people do still have doorbells for a reason, huh.”

“But she wasn’t here when you got here, so you just thought you’d break in?”

They were wandering into the large reception room now, the various furniture breaking it up providing them with something of a maze in the dark. Jonah was reluctant to even use his smartphone torch in there, since people out front might see it through the large window.

Jonah said: “I think she’s involved with some kind of organization.”

“Organization?”

He looked at the guy, and sighed. It was hard to trust a journalist. But Keeley could be useful to the investigation. Jonah said, “I’ve heard it called ‘The Network’. I don’t know a lot about it yet, but I think it involves people in the City, and maybe others invited to be members.”

“And what does it do, this Network?”

“On the surface, it seems to arrange dates for wives. And as far as I’ve been able to tell, it’s with their husbands’ full approval.”

“And under the surface?”

“I don’t know. But they might be involved in some kind of stock market...

scheme. As I said, I don’t know enough about it yet.” Jonah didn’t exactly feel that a couple of pieces of card with letters printed on them constituted the kind of evidence suitable for a newspaper reporter.

“So what’s the plan, Sherlock?” Keeley asked. “You think it might be a better idea to just come back during office hours? If you think she might talk to you.”

Jonah felt oddly bullish. “And you’re a journalist, you say?” he joked. “Come on. Or leave me to it. I just want to take a look upstairs. They’ve got a study up there.”

“What do you think you’ll find?”

He shrugged. “Don’t know. Perhaps nothing. Perhaps she’s just a widow with a libido, and the whole Network thing is just some great City institution that our murder victims all just happened to belong to.”

“Uh-huh,” Keeley said, ducking behind the curtain at the side of the bay window at the front of the house, taking a look outside as Jonah headed through to the entrance hallway and the staircase to the upper floor.

As he ascended the staircase, he was looking for signs of any kind of burglar alarms, or CCTV cameras, but there was nothing at all that he could see. Was

this some kind of crime-free area where people didn’t have to worry about break-ins?

Keeley scampered up the stairs as Jonah was reaching the top step. He said: “No sign of anyone coming for us.”

Jonah shook his head as though he’d been expecting it. “Seems funny, doesn’t it?

There’s no security at all. For the wife of a murdered government minister, you’d expect something, right?” Despite the apparent lack of security, they were still speaking in hushed tones.

“Well, he wasn’t Northern Ireland secretary. If he had been, we wouldn’t be here now.”

“Right. And Lord Moss probably wouldn’t be dead, either.”

“Depends who the Black Widow turns out to be. If it’s his wife, then there was nothing MI5 or Special Branch could have done.”

“Hey, look at these.”

Jonah ushered the reporter over to look at the framed photographs hung up along the wall of the upstairs hallway. By the light of his smartphone torch, the scenes of dinner parties took on a different nuance for Jonah, given his brief experiences with the Network.

“They liked to entertain, huh?” Keeley said.

Jonah said, “And I think in these photographs... maybe Lady Moss was the entertainment.”

Keeley drew in his breath. “This is all part of that Network of yours?”

“I just get the feeling it is.”

The first time he’d come here, as a visitor glancing at these pictures on his way to the bathroom, Jonah had seen these pictures as the Moss family glorying in their establishment credentials, remembering their great social achievements in years gone by.

This time, though, he was looking at them in a different light.

“But not all of them are, right?” Keeley said, looking at some of the pictures further down the hallway. “I mean, Jesus, this is the transport minister in this one. And isn’t this Donnie Dayglow? And here’s Richard Seymore, the record producer... And fuck me if that isn’t a James Bond sitting right there with the good Lady herself...”

As Jonah looked at them, even the pictures with famous faces sitting around the dinner table, it seemed there were very few female dinner guests ever in attendance. Some, here and there, but not many at all. Not the usual balanced picture you might normally expect for formal dinner parties in the affluent classes.

Lady Moss herself, in every picture, was dressed in very glamorous evening wear that always appeared to Jonah to be just a touch too revealing for a normal dinner party.

And the look in Lord Moss's eye as the camera captured the scene for posterity seemed to Jonah not unlike the way Lydia's husband had been looking during that dinner party at the private hotel in Chelsea. He was nervous yet exhilarated, anticipating what was to come: another man, whoever it was, spending intimate time with his wife.

"They're all over the place up here," Jonah said. "Lord Moss was really flaunting his sharing her, huh?"

Keeley nodded. "Probably got off on it. On visitors seeing these pictures."

Jonah actually felt a little better now. Having had another chance to look at these pictures, he felt more confident in his assumption that Lady Moss was participating in Network activities. If he could speak to her, he would have that card in his hand, and it might be used to get her to open up about the organization—and whether the Black Widow might be a member.

And what of her own status as a suspect? Well, perhaps he could take a little more care, make sure Mulray was there when he spoke to her—trip her up, with his knowledge about the Network, if indeed she was the killer.

"You think all of these guys at these dinner parties knew what was going on with

Lord and Lady Moss?" Keeley asked.

"I don't know. I think it's possible."

Keeley was ducking his head into some of the rooms along the hallway, apparently less concerned about their safety than Jonah was. He didn't seem impressed by any of the bedrooms, the nursery.

He said: "The rich and the powerful exist in a world of their own, you know that?"

“I suppose so,” Jonah said. “Come on, the study’s this way. I just want a quick look in there. Then we can go.”

“Whenever I’ve dealt with them, it’s been that way. We think of how we would be, if we suddenly came into money—and that’s how we assume the ruling classes really are. But they play under completely different rules.”

“Right.”

Inside the study, there was a lit desk lamp sitting on the large desk positioned in front of the windows overlooking the garden, and it shed a useful amount of light around the room. Jonah walked past the old leather couches that seemed to take up much of the space in the room in front of the fireplace, then he slumped in the large green leather chair behind the desk.

The fact that the lamp was on meant that Lady Moss still came in here. Still used this desk. Did she use the Mac computer sitting in the corner of the desk?

Keeley was peering at more of the photographs of dinner parties. “None of this should surprise me,” he said. “But these kind of things always do, whenever I deal with these sort of people.”

Jonah fired up the Mac, and it booted up with a disturbingly loud chime so beloved of Apple machines.

“Hey, are you nuts?” Keeley hissed, and Jonah realized that the light from the screen might, conceivably, be seen out of the window from a house on Duke Road. Improbable—but then even a small possibility was too much.

“It’s okay,” he insisted, drawing the curtains across the windows to provide a blackout shield.

The Mosses might not have the kind of paperwork mountains that Julian had maintained in his tiny study at the house in Shepherd’s Bush, but perhaps there would be signs of what they were up to somewhere on their computer. It was a fairly old Mac, high spec for its time, but with its age it took a while to boot up.

“This is where you found that book?” Keeley asked, as he now scanned the spines of some of the books lining the bookshelves dominating the room. “The one Julian Foster wrote.”

“Uh-huh. Down there on that shelf with the paperbacks. Didn’t see anything else of interest, though.”

The computer was taking a while to get through its start-up routine, it was making him nervous. What should he be looking for anyway, once it started up?

Was he hoping for a folder called “The Network”? Or perhaps one labeled,

“Black Widow”? All this was probably a wild stab in the dark.

He also had the whole ethics of this situation to worry about. Jesus, there could be personal stuff in here. If Lady Moss was just some poor innocent next-of-kin like he was, was it really ethical to pry into her personal information? Sure, she might have her secrets, and if she and her husband liked to entertain guests in their bed, then no wonder she’d been reluctant to talk about them with strangers

—and with a police detective present.

Perhaps his whole ends-justified-the-means view on this investigation was wrong. Or perhaps he just needed to bite the bullet, and start clicking on folders with the little mouse sitting there in front of the large computer screen. He might be infringing on her privacy, but then he would clear her of suspicion, and they could all move on.

The computer finished starting up, and Jonah groaned. Of course—it required a password to get in.

He didn’t have much time to worry about that, though. Keeley let out a hiss of warning. The man was leaning out of the study door now, his head turned oddly, as he listened for danger signs.

“There’s a light gone on, outside the front,” he said in a loud whisper. “I saw it flash through the bedroom.”



“Probably just a car going by,” Jonah said, but he was on edge, too. Keeley’s fear was contagious.

“No,” Keeley took a few steps into the bedroom opposite, as close to the window as he dared.

Jonah waited, one heartbeat, two heartbeats, three.

“There’s a car in the driveway!” the reporter hissed. “Come on—let’s go. Now!”

He was gone, not sticking around to wait and see if Jonah agreed with his strategy. Jonah looked at the big bright display of the Mac computer, terrified that if he left this computer on, it would be seen lighting up the study even beyond the dull glow of the desk lamp, anyone out there in the hallway would know instantly that someone had been here.

He paused a moment or two, then guided the mouse cursor to the “cancel” link below the password prompt in the middle of the screen. The computer was frustratingly slow in responding. One second, two seconds, three seconds—each one, making his escape from this house more difficult. Then, at last, the monitor faded to black.

Only, now from downstairs he heard the sound of the front door being unlocked and opened—clear as clear could be. Lady Moss, no doubt, was back from her evening out.

Jonah was trapped.

## **Five**

“How about in here? You can make me look all sophisticated...”

Jonah groaned as the door to the study opened, and Lady Moss entered the room, wearing pearls, pink stilettos and a pink dress that buttoned up in the front—but on which all the buttons were now unfastened, to reveal white lace underwear underneath.

The man who came in behind her was unmistakably Reynolds, the butler, though he was dressed down in a sweater, shirt and gray slacks instead of donning his usual suit.

“I don’t need to make you look sophisticated, sweetness...”

His tone of voice surprised Jonah too, although it only confirmed his earlier suspicions that the butler may have been comforting his employer since her husband’s death in more ways than simply being a reliable manservant.

Lady Moss perched on the end of the leather sofa, reaching forward to pick up a long, thin cigarette holder that had been resting on an ashtray on the coffee table, and a cigarette from the box sitting next to it.

As she crossed her shapely legs, the sight drew Jonah’s eye for a moment or two

—so that he almost missed the fact that Reynolds was now walking over toward the window, to close the curtains behind which Jonah was hiding.

All he could do now was keep still, as far possible, and hope the man didn’t look behind the righthand curtain before drawing it across the window. His heart started pounding, louder with every step the butler took toward him. What would he say to them when he was discovered?

Jonah found himself flinching as the butler reached out for the thick velvet that was shielding him.

Then Lady Moss said in a very casual tone: “You know, the next breeding party

is this weekend.”

Reynolds stopped still, then turned, his hand still on the curtain, just inches away from Jonah’s face. Jesus, he could count the wrinkles on the man’s knuckles.

“You think I should go?” Lady Moss said, and exhaled a long plume of cigarette smoke.

“I thought you were supposed to. As a member.”

She smiled. “But do you think I should participate? Watching from the sidelines is so damn passive.”

Reynolds paused, then drew the curtains rapidly across the window, Jonah heaving a huge sigh of relief that he remained concealed behind them.

“You think it’s a good idea?” the man said, his voice calm, even. Not betraying his thoughts.

Jonah took a risk and stepped across to peer through the tiny gap between the curtains. He could see Lady Moss giving the man a mischievous look, a little shrug of the shoulders.

“Might be fun, don’t you think?” she said. “Like the old days.”

Breeding party? What was that? Jonah found himself

“If you think so, my lady.”

The butler sat down on the opposite end of the sofa to Lady Moss, looking at her as she reclined there, flaunting herself with her dress open to reveal a white lace corset, which accentuated her elegant figure. He remained quite calm, though.

Lady Moss was teasing him, but it seemed to Jonah that Reynolds was similarly teasing her with his calm demeanor—more than anything, she wanted to make him react.

She said: “The Network’s all very well, but it can get tedious, don’t you think?”

Unless one lucks out with a stallion...”

She did a little shimmy in her seat as though remembering a stallion in particular. Her eyes on him, taunting him.

“Yes, my lady.”

“Makes one crave a little more... risk. You know what I mean?”

She sucked on the end of the cigarette holder, letting the smoke fill her lungs, then smiled at her butler, if that was really what he was. Companion, might be the better word from how they were treating each other.

Reynolds got up from the couch, and went to the door, ducking to retrieve something from a leather holdall that was sitting by one of the room's many bookshelves.

A camera.

It wasn't quite the huge paparazzi-style camera, but it was still a full digital SLR, something to take proper photographs with, more than just holiday snaps.

Lady Moss was smiling as he walked over to her, and straightened her dress so that it flowed down revealing her breasts, as covered by the white lace corset.

"You never used to take pictures of me after a night out," she said. "Not when we first started out, anyway."

"No, my lady."

"Just since Douglas passed away."

"It made me notice how you look... afterwards... my lady."

He was clicking away with the camera, stepping back, around, catching her from different angles. The elegant blonde looked perfectly comfortable in front of a lens, showing herself off for the camera, her hands slowly running down her chest, brushing away her dress to highlight her figure.

"You like how I look afterwards?" she asked him.

"You look... wonderful."

She smiled broadly at that.

After a few moments, she picked herself up off the sofa, then knelt on it with one knee, and Jonah could see her matching white panties, and the white stockings hooked up to her corset. Elegant, sexy, breath-taking.

Reynolds fired away with his camera, with his model moving and turning to offer him a multitude of aspects.

Then she removed her dress completely, allowing it to fall to the floor, providing her photographer a slow dance in her underwear while she toked on the cigarette.

Reynolds stepped this way and that, knelt from afar or from close up to take this picture or that, appearing the consummate professional, though he was hardly a professional photographer.

“I love it when you take pictures of me,” she said, perching on the arm of the sofa while he continued to record her image.

Then she slumped down, sitting on the couch, relaxing, Reynolds taking her picture from directly in front, no doubt glorying her display of those long, stocking-clad legs.

“You know I love it most when we’re out and you’re taking pictures of me?”

Reynolds looked up from his camera and smiled.

“When I’m being naughty, and you’re there to focus on me,” she said, parting her thighs, opening her legs for him to see.

“Yes, my lady.”

Her fingers dropped down between her thighs, over her mound. “It always surprises me how nervous you look, before everything gets going. Even after all this time, when I’m on a date... or at a party... and you know someone else has their eye on me. You know I’m going to be enjoying them...”

She giggled as Reynolds moved away, around to the side of the sofa again, taunting her with his unflustered composure either consciously or not.

She swung round and knelt up on the sofa again, saying: “It’s such a turn-on,

you know that? Looking you in the eye when another man fucks me...”

She began crawling along the sofa toward her photographer, prowling like a panther as he continued clicking the shutter, snapping image after

image.

“...when he’s fucking me and it feels so good... you’re trying to hide behind your camera, but I can see your erection, you know that?”

Reynolds dropped the camera. With his back to Jonah, he couldn’t see the man’s expression, but it was obviously amusing Lady Moss. She reached for his camera, pulled it out of his grip, reached out to place it on the coffee table.

“And the harder he fucks me, the harder you get,” she said softly, seductively.

She grabbed his hand, pulled him to the sofa, and Reynolds did as she wanted, sitting, allowing her to stroke his cheek, then kiss his lips, her hand spreading over his chest.

They were affectionate, the two of them. Their kiss delicate, soft, loving. More than just a physical thing, more than just a brief affair.

Lady Moss ran her hand down between his legs, where Jonah couldn’t quite see what she was doing, but could imagine what was on her mind. She turned away from his face as she explored his lap with her fingers, Reynolds now kissing her gently down her cheek, and her neck.

Had they been lovers while Lord Moss had still been alive? Certainly she’d already said he was taking pictures of her before her husband had died.

Presumably that was as lovers.

Lady Moss lifted her leg and straddled her manservant, pressing herself down on his hardness as she began kissing his mouth once more. Stirring her hips, rubbing herself on him, she lifted up her head as his kisses descended down her neck, over her chest, along the top of her corset.

“Was tonight fun for you?” she asked him, in barely more than a whisper.

“Of course,” he said. “As always.”

Jonah could see the man’s hands clasping her round buttocks, squeezing her,

reveling in her gorgeous curves.

“I always feel so selfish,” she smiled, leaning back to make it easy for his hands to cup her breasts, to fondle them within their lace confines. “I mean, I know nothing feels as good as a new man...”

“Nothing feels as good as watching you enjoying a new man,” said Reynolds gently, making her smile.

Jonah felt a strange envy for Reynolds, that he could enjoy such a beauty as Lady Moss, that she was apparently his, though she played with others as well.

They had undeniable chemistry. The way he held her, the way he touched her.

The way she looked at him. It was nothing less than adoration, all round.

The dark-haired butler slipped her breasts out of the lace now, his lips finding their way around her stiff nipples as she gently held him around the back of the neck.

They were about the same age, too. Lady Moss was what, mid-thirties?

Reynolds couldn't be much more, though there was a silver hair or two on his head.

Jonah felt the burning sensation in his chest that stemmed from knowing he was finding out things no police investigation would. But was any of this motive for murder?

Was Lady Moss a killer?

Watching them brought to mind that great Agatha Christie mystery, *Death on the Nile*, and lengths to which the nefarious couple at the heart of the story were prepared to do to get their hands on a fortune. Would Reynolds have stood by while his lover married Lord Moss in order to get their hands on his fortune?

But if there was such a clear-cut motive, why kill all the other men? Surely they couldn't all have stumbled onto such a plot?

Jonah watched as Lady Moss now stood up, in front of Reynolds. Dancing, slowly and erotically for him, her thumbs tucked in the waistband of her panties.

She turned, and pulled them down, stepped out of them. Jonah could see a brief

glimpse of the little triangle of golden down between her legs, but then she was leaning over her lover, teasing him by keeping her bare sex away from him, working to unfasten his belt and his fly.

“Look how hard you are,” she said, stepping to the side as her hands freed up his manhood. “You like taking pictures of me with another man’s big prick inside me, don’t you?”

He nodded, and reached for her, his hand curling around her thigh, nudging against her bare pussy. He stroked her as she stroked him, and as she looked down at him he filled his mouth with her breast and its stiff nipple.

Jonah stretched up on tip-toes, found another hole in the curtains so that he could see a little more over the arm of the sofa. He could see the ample size Reynolds was wielding. Probably something a woman like Lady Moss would want to keep in her life, even if she had access to any other man she fancied. The man was so fired up by her, by how she was after her evening with another man. And Jonah could appreciate why—she did have a certain radiance about her, a freshly-fucked confidence that went beyond the simple beauty of her appearance.

“He was bigger than you,” she said softly now. “The one tonight. I swear, he stretched me like I’ve never been stretched before.”

“You liked that?”

“I’m getting so wet, just thinking about it, can you tell?”

As he watched her sink down on him, taking his pole inside her mouth, Jonah found himself automatically picturing himself in Reynolds’s role, and that Emma was the beautiful woman going down on him—after a night enjoying the wicked pleasures of other men.



Lady Moss was rewarding him, but also enjoying how he reacted to her misbehavior, savoring just how hard he was.

If Douglas Moss had discovered her love for Reynolds, would he have objected to it? If the man had been a wife-sharer anyway, perhaps not. Was Lady Moss even someone who seemed capable of murder? She did seem to have an inner, steely resolve. Her intelligence, her innate power—she was a more believable candidate than anyone he'd yet come across. But did he believe she was the

killer? He felt oddly neutral.

Reynolds urged her up, kissing her mouth, touching her breasts, but now guiding her around, to sit on the couch while he knelt on the floor before her, parting her thighs to allow himself in to plant kisses around her bare pussy. She was smooth, hairless other than the little blonde triangle on her mound. He seemed to enjoy her flavor well enough, even after an evening in the company of another man.

Lady Moss lay back on the couch and moaned as her manservant lapped at her tender pink flower.

And as he ate her, she kept talking, as though it only encouraged him, saying things like, “Oh, you love it, don't you? How it tastes after it's been stretched by another cock....”

And, “You love how wet I am thinking of him fucking me...”

And, “My pussy's an aphrodisiac to you, isn't it? Especially when it's been used all night by someone else...”

Much as the sight excited Jonah, his own pole hard as a rock in his pants, he started wondering if there might be some opportunity for him to escape. Lady Moss closed her eyes as her dutiful lover feasted on her, slipping his fingers inside her as he sucked on her clit. But would she be able to see Jonah creeping past, even in the shadows?

Reynolds was focused on drawing out the beautiful blonde woman's moans, nothing in his view but her stunning body, writhing and panting on the way to orgasm. But could he look up and see movement as another man attempted to leave the room?

Jonah suspected there wasn't quite enough room for him to get by without detection. It would be too obvious.

Then Reynolds was pulling himself up onto his knees, removing his shirt to reveal a toned torso that a butler had no right to have in Jonah's book, and he was guiding the tip of his impressive cock to her glistening, rosy pussy lips, and when he started edging it inside her, any hope of Jonah getting past them undiscovered evaporated again.

"Slowly," Lady Moss told him, but the broad smile on her face told of how she adored feeling him inside her. "It's still a little tender. He spent most of the evening in there..."

Reynolds had an impressive physique—he made Jonah want to suddenly get into the gym, even though he wasn't particularly unfit himself. The way he squeezed into her, the way she responded to his filling her, made Jonah believe that any comments she made about enjoying other men, and that other men were larger than Reynolds, meant nothing against how her real lover made her feel.

He tensed and flexed his muscular form with each thrust inside her, and she was perfectly satisfied with how he made her feel.

He was even powerful enough to lift her up onto the arm of the sofa while he was still inside her, before continuing to fuck her while standing up.

She came, hard, as his thrusts accelerated into an intense pounding, regardless of her earlier pleas for him to be gentle. Reynolds, though, remained rock-hard, the enormous thing bobbing in the air as he withdrew from her, to sit down on the couch so that she might ride him on his lap.

Jonah found that envy for the man—as the delectable Lady Moss climbed onto him, then guided him back inside her—translated into a deep longing for Emma.

What was she up to? He could understand it if someone so sexually free had doubts about any kind of long-term relationship, but why was she keeping so distant from him?

Was it not hurting her as much as it hurt him?

For a moment, Jonah was lost in a daze of his own making, so much so that he accidentally stirred the curtain while he stood there. It jolted him out of his thoughts, sending a chill through his body.

He stood still for a few moments, and the sounds of Lady Moss moaning as she fucked her secret lover continued—although now she was giggling about something.

Jonah peered through the hole in the curtain to see that she was still sitting on the man's lap, her hips circling on him, pumping him inside her, but she was now

sitting up, holding Reynolds's camera in her hands, to look at its little screen.

"I was so red in the face when he was fucking me that hard," she was saying.

Reynolds grunted a single word, "Beautiful."

Lady Moss smiled, "You're crazy, you know that, sweetie? But I guess I gave up trying to understand you long ago, and just enjoy the ride."

"You understand... I love you..." Reynolds said.

"Of course," she leaned forward to kiss him tenderly.

"And... you understand... I want nothing but the best for you..."

"Well sure..."

"So there's nothing else you need to understand," he said.

She cradled his head in her hands, gazing deeply into his eyes as she slowly continued to rise and fall on his manhood. "You know I love, you right?"

He nodded.

Then after a moment or two, Lady Moss broke out into a broad smile, holding up the camera between them again, saying: "You'll have to

remember to take pictures of other women, too, you know—at the weekend. The members will be disappointed if they're all of me.”

Reynolds smiled, kissed her neck. “I’m sure they won’t be disappointed, my Lady, with pictures of you.”

She giggled, but then Reynolds was holding her to him, his hands clasp her buttocks, increasing the pace of her grinding on him. She quickly dropped the camera on the sofa beside them, then her eyes closed, and her breathing turned to panting as she held his head firm in her arms and rode him like a racehorse.

When he came, it seemed that she did as well, again, yelping as she held him so tight it was like she was trying to crush him.

Stretching up on tip-toes, Jonah could see the man’s huge cock pumping like a

piston into her, until her movement came to a halt, and she slumped against him, both of them struggling to regain their breaths.

With their movement ceasing, Jonah had to make extra special effort not to make a sound.

After what seemed like an age, the beautiful blonde disengaged from her manservant, climbing off him, fetching her dress from the floor to drape it over her shoulders again—though not without giving her lover a final show, a last look of her phenomenal body before she covered herself up.

“It’s late,” she said, “I have to call my dear mother-in-law, to check on Christopher.”

“Of course, my Lady,” the butler said mildly. “I have my duties.”

## **Six**

He had to wait a while longer before he felt safe enough to come out from behind that curtain. He stood there, silent, listening, relieved that he remained undiscovered, but nervous about how he might escape the house.

It had been a hairy moment or two when Reynolds had come back to the desk to switch off the lamp. Jonah felt certain the man might see him through the gap in the curtains. But the butler was distracted by the pictures on his camera, which he took with him when he left the study, and left Jonah in the darkness there within.

Would the man be sleeping with the lady of the house, once his household duties were done for the night? From the sound of it, it seemed not. And yet the two of them were so clearly a couple, unconventionally at least.

Waiting there, he heard a shower starting up within some distant en suite. Lady Moss, preparing for bed in the master bedroom. Hearing her stepping under the flow of the water, he felt one of the barriers to his escape was now safely occupied. But where was Reynolds?

Jonah felt his mobile phone in his pocket, and retrieved it as though it might offer some idea for escape.

There was a message—from Keeley, no less.

*>You okay? I think I still see you there in the window. They see you?*

He tapped out a message, sent it back:

*>They didn't see me. Too into each other. Seems like they've been an item before she was even married to Lord Moss.*

Keeley's reply was a few moments coming, but wherever he was now, he'd certainly been monitoring his phone.

*>Interesting. Think you could get out the window? From here, looks like you could get across the conservatory roof, drop down without too much hurt.*

Jonah peered out of the dark window, and he could see the glass roof of the conservatory below. It seemed like a steep incline—he wasn't tempted to go for it. Not when he was fairly sure he only had to get past Reynolds, and then there would be an open door down there for him to leave the back of the house.

*>Looks a bit steep. You think there's any way I could get past the password on the computer here?*

*>No time. Get out of there. If they left the back door open tonight, chances are they will again, we can come back some time. Too risky now.*

Jonah felt it was the right approach. He texted back:

*>She's going to a big Network event this weekend. We could try then.*

*>Great. Now get out.*

*>Can you see where Reynolds is in the house? Lady Moss is safely in the shower, I think.*

*>Only see which windows are lit at the back of the house. I don't think he's downstairs, though. No lights now.*

Jonah pushed his way tentatively through the curtains, and crept to the doorway.

He could still hear Lady Moss in the shower, over in the master bedroom. He edged his head out of the doorway, checking this way, then that.

The hallway was darkened now, leaving lights on in the master bedroom, and a room on the opposite end of the house, the other side of the study. Was Reynolds in that room?

Jonah heard the quiet screech of hangers being moved along a rail in the bedroom nearby. It had to be Reynolds.

It was enough confirmation for Jonah: he bolted out of the study, thankful that this house was large, but not so old, the floorboards solid underfoot, allowing him to proceed to the landing and the staircase without creaks.

The minimalist style of furnishing aided Jonah's escape as he fled through the large reception room, and through the kitchen to the conservatory, not looking back.

The mobile phone lit up as another text message came through from Keeley:

*>Be careful as you come out—they could see you through an upstairs window.*

Jonah eased open the door to the garden, and edged out slowly, making no sudden movements. The chill of the air seemed somehow sweet—the sweet sense of freedom.

“Come on, out the back,” Keeley whispered. The reporter was right there, he couldn’t really see him in the gloom, the garden dominated by huge trees that blocked out moonlight and streetlight just the same.

“We’ll come back,” the reporter said, patting him on the shoulder. “We’ll come back.”

“Right. You know how to get past the password on that computer?”

Keeley grinned, “I know a few guys who might.”

## Seven

He took things easy that week, thinking it probably best to rest and make sure he was in perfect shape if he and the reporter were going to make another attempt at a break-in while Lady Moss went out to the big Network event.

He managed to get an early night on the Friday, and even managed to avoid worrying about Emma for a while. If she wanted to go off and date someone else

—male or female— while she considered whether she wanted to be with him long-term, then so be it.

But then he woke up on Saturday morning to find a text from Emma that destroyed any hope of a leisurely day preparing for a night of law-breaking.

*>I said you’d be up for a lunch date, sound okay? Network people again, I’m pretty sure. Can you be at Hazlitt’s at 1pm?*

Well, any contact with Emma might throw out all his plans, of course. A lunch date—did this mean a sex date? If it was Network people, then chances were that it would be. Would Mulray be there to oversee it again, or would Emma be there?

His heart leapt at the hope of seeing her again. And of course, he couldn't think of declining the offer, of disappointing her.

He texted back:

> *Sure. Will I get to see you there?*

A few moments later, the message came back:

> *Might do. Wear a suit. Xx*

Hazlitt's was a small hotel in a Georgian townhouse within the narrow maze of streets in the Soho area, close to busy Oxford Street. Jonah was a little confused when he got there, since it didn't much look like a hotel. Looked more like a

private home, or a boutique museum, perhaps devoted to teddy bears or Jane Austen.

"Okay, so they're in the Library, and it's just them, so you won't miss them."

Emma was behind him, and he couldn't believe he'd failed to spot her—or that she'd snuck up on him like that.

God, she looked amazing. Was her hair a touch darker than the last time he'd seen her? Her freckles were somehow more apparent—had she always looked so fresh-faced and just damn pretty?

She was wearing a black jacket, and a floral scarf, not particularly ostentatious, but just seeing her there made his heart throb with longing. He had to keep calm, of course. Couldn't freak her out while she was trying to get her head around his wanting to be with her longer than a handful of one night stands.

"'Them', you said?" he asked, feeling a touch of awkwardness between them despite his massive attraction toward her. Or perhaps because of it.

She nodded. "The other guy is already there. Two wives, they play together. I think you'll like them," she grinned. "The brunette is going by Tasha, and the blonde is Ashley. Not sure if those are their real names or not. I guess it doesn't matter."



“Husbands present this time?”

“Not as far as I know. They’re just taking a break from shopping at Selfridge’s.”

“How lovely. Beats tea at the Ritz, I suppose. And you’ll be watching this time, not your new best buddy Detective Mulray?”

“Of course,” she said, handing him the pair of horn-rimmed glasses in which the camera was installed, and the little black earpiece through which he might hear her voice. “I’m here, aren’t I?”

He put the glasses on, and slipped the earpiece into his ear, trying not to get too caught up in the hope that Emma was still interested in him, that her experimenting still left her wanting him.

“So, the Library, huh?” he raised his eyebrows.

“Okay, have fun,” she said, giving him a quick peck on the cheek. “See you afterwards.”



The hotel was cosy inside. Its relatively small size, authentic paneled white walls and antique furniture, complete with old gilt-framed paintings, gave the place an air of exclusivity and centuries-old privilege.

But the décor was a little excessively done for Jonah’s taste, almost verging on parody.

A smart-looking gentleman dressed like someone from Downton Abbey steered him through from the reception area to the Library. Sure enough two fairly young women were seated on the luxurious red floral couches in front of a blazing fire in the fireplace, with a familiar face seated opposite them. Liam.

The bookshelves around the walls reminded Jonah a little of Lady Moss’s study

—but the décor was so much more ornate than the minimalist style of the Moss household.

“Well, hey, you must be Robert,” the brunette, Tasha, flashed him a smile as she looked him up and down, making it quite obvious she was sizing him up for a little early-afternoon bedroom activity.

“I’m sorry I’m a little late,” he said.

Tasha was wearing designer jeans and a white blouse, with a brown leather jacket over the top that Jonah supposed might cost the same as a family car.

Ashley was wearing a short crimson and cream floral dress that showed off her figure a little more than Tasha’s outfit, though both women were as stunning as trophy wives were expected to be.

“Oh, you’re right on time,” she said. “I’m Tasha, by the way. My friend is Ashley. And this is...”

“Liam, hi,” Jonah shook the man’s hand, and he responded with a warm smile.

“I guess they decided we were compatible, old man,” Liam said.

As Jonah took a seat on the sofa beside Liam, another Downton Abbey-esque member of the hotel staff offered him a glass of Champagne, which he accepted with a slight nod.

“Well, I’m impressed,” Tasha declared, swigging from her own Champagne, and sounding as though she’d had more than a glass or two already. “You two are quite something.”

“You’ve done well, sweetie,” Ashley said to her friend.

Liam smiled, “You can save the flattery for afterwards.”

Jonah was mildly surprised by the man’s confidence, his certainty that all of this was leading to sex with these women. But then, he had been doing this a lot longer than Jonah.

“And your husbands are busy, I suppose?” Jonah asked, and Liam silently looked him in the eye and raised his eyebrows, amused at the rookie asking the kind of question that perhaps wasn’t overtly asked during a Network event.

Tasha and Ashley didn’t bat an eyelid at the question. The blonde said: “Our husbands are happy for us to spend the day as we like.”

Tasha shared her friend’s smile, “You know, we’ve been best friends since school? And we always did share the same taste in men, turns out we shared the same taste in husbands, too.”

“Uh-huh,” Ashley said. “Husbands who like us to look good and feel good, and if that means a little playing around with some fine young gentlemen like yourselves, then so be it.”

“They sound very civilized,” Liam said.

“Well,” Tasha rose to her feet, her friend following suit by her lead. “I’m sure it’s time we freshened up. See you upstairs?”

“Looking forward to it,” Liam took the brunette’s hand and stooped to kiss it like some Disney-style Prince Charming.

The women were giggling as they left the Library to ready themselves.

It felt a touch odd to be left sitting there with Liam in front of a warm fire, waiting to go upstairs for an afternoon orgy. It could have been worse, though.

At least he’d met the guy before.

“How long do we wait for them?” he asked, breaking the ice.

“Well, we don’t want to just go leaping in,” Liam said, seeming to accept Jonah’s lack of experience in these matters, as though it left him in a good light.

“We show a little class, relax and let them get the pleasantries out of the way...”

“The pleasantries?”

The dark-haired man smiled broadly. “Of course, we don’t want to miss all of it.

Give them a little time to get warmed up... fifteen, twenty minutes?”

“Then we just go up there?”

He chuckled, “Well, they want us to catch them, right? At least, that’s the impression I get. Part of the thrill for them, being bad.”

“Oh, right.”

“And hey, they can get all the foreplay out of the way so we can go straight in, right?”

At that, Jonah heard Emma’s voice in his ear: “Charming.” In reminding him that she was there, watching his every step, it started a fire inside him.



Liam slipped the key card in the lock and the mechanism opened with a loud series of grinding clicks. He looked at Jonah, and flicked his head to indicate it was time to go in.

Jonah nodded, and followed the man into the room.

Inside, the lights were down low and the warm air was filled with the combined perfumes of the two wives.

Jonah followed Liam a few steps down a small hallway into the main chamber of the suite. It wasn’t huge for a luxury hotel suite, but the furnishings were impressive, if not a little over-done and gaudy. There were couches circled around a coffee table, looking onto another roaring fireplace, but the suite looked through to the bedroom where there was an impressive four-poster bed, complete with two naked wives lounging on it.

“Couldn’t wait any longer, huh?” Tasha teased.

Liam smiled, calm despite the startling scene. He said, “And miss the show?”

Tasha, the brunette, was lying back against the pillows propped up against the headboard, her legs parted as she gazed down on her friend, who knelt over her, both hands between her thighs to pleasure her.

They were both as beautiful without their clothes, bodies toned by a gym routine uninterrupted by any need to work for a living.

Jonah matched Liam’s move to the couches, trying to make it seem as though he wasn’t simply taking his lead from the other man, though that was exactly what he was doing. As they took their seats with a good view of the bed, the women continued their own thing as though nobody else was there.

Tasha tilted her head back and sank into the pillows, her eyes closing and her mouth opening as though in silent prayer. Ashley was using one hand to penetrate her sweet pussy, with the other pressing against her clit.

The blonde seemed practiced at this, at getting her friend off. It suggested to Jonah that they’d been truthful in their story about being such long-time friends.

He and Liam might have missed the initial foreplay between these two women, but to Jonah the way they were together made it appear that they were not merely being bisexual as a way to thrill or shock their male audience.

Tasha moaned as her friend fucked her with her fingers, grabbing the pillows as her body writhed under the forceful manipulation. Her cheeks pink, her nipples jutting upwards, there was nothing faked about her response.

Ashley’s hands were on rapid-fire, past any pretense of delicate sensuality into the realms of certain intense climax. She built her friend up into a frenzy, and then as the wave hit, she ducked down to envelop Tasha’s clit in her mouth, the brunette holding her head as her tongue slipped out to push inside her for the shuddering orgasm that tore through her body.

The two women were laughing at the power of Tasha’s climax, Ashley sliding up over her friend, the two touching their foreheads together as

Tasha recovered her breath.

“God that was wild,” the brunette said, gazing up at her friend with familiar gratitude and affection.

Tasha pulled the blonde up so she could reach to take one of her nipples into her mouth, both hands squeezing her breasts as she sucked on her sensitive bud.

Ashley pulled herself up further, Tasha wriggling under her so the blonde could straddle her face.

From this angle, they could see only Ashley’s beautiful curves, her shapely behind, her thighs parted over Tasha’s head. They could see the faint definitions of muscles moving in Tasha’s delicate neck as she worked on her friend. They could hear the brunette’s quiet moaning in enjoyment as Ashley slowly rocked her hips back and forth.

Watching them, Jonah found himself envying the women for their experience, though the very thrilling prospect of joining them quelled such feelings somewhat. The air was electric. The scent of female arousal pervading the room put him on edge.

He looked across at Liam, who was trying to keep calm while enjoying the show.

The other man glanced at him, and gave a slight shake of the head—indicating: not yet. Give them time. Assuming that Jonah’s look his way was some kind of

question as to whether they should be moving in on the bed, perhaps doing something about Tasha’s highly exposed yet under-occupied sex.

Ashley rode her friend’s face much harder than Jonah would have expected, laughing as she took pleasure from her friend’s mouth.

But she didn’t climax that way. She pulled herself off, her behind slipping onto the mattress where she could almost curl up around Tasha’s head, brushing her golden hair back out of her face as she kissed her lips, both of them giggling.

Tasha picked herself up, wiping the perspiration from her reddened face, and Ashley presented herself on all fours for her to sweep her hands all over her behind, her fingers slipping inside the blonde's pussy for the same kind of furious climax as she herself had just enjoyed.

Tasha looked, to Jonah, like a gamer going for a high score as she thrust her fingers inside her whimpering friend, driving Ashley relentlessly on toward her orgasm. Yet when it hit, the brunette melted into a sudden tenderness, applying her soft mouth and tongue to Ashley's shivering pussy, then moving up to hold her while the force of the climax took hold, kissing her gently, caressing her as her cries faded.

It was that caressing afterward that seemed drawn out. The two women enjoying each others' touch there on the bed, the gentle brush of each others' hands over their soft skin, the sweet connection of lips on lips. Even just the wickedness of lying naked before an audience.

But they were teasing the menfolk, and after a while both giggled at what they were up to, before turning in unison to acknowledge the presence of Jonah and Liam.

Jonah could see Liam in his peripheral vision acting cool, collecting, perhaps giving only a slight nod at the knowledge that they were just about to engage with these two straying wives. He tried to match the other man's calm.

Then after a final kiss, Tasha pulled away from her friend, both of them rising from the bed to wander hand in hand over to their waiting suitors.

Did they have an agreement between them? As they approached, the two women parted, the blonde heading for Liam while the brunette zeroed in on Jonah.

Jonah had to shuffle in his seat to make room for his flourishing erection as Tasha stepped toward him, barely concealed lust in her dark eyes. Standing tall, prim, confident, she was certainly something to behold, her figure trim yet shapely, her breasts poised and pert, her legs slender yet strong, her stomach enviably flat, leading the eye over her small dark landing strip to the irresistible promise between her thighs.

She almost strutted over to him, confidence in every movement. It wasn't just her beauty that led her to be that way, Jonah suspected—plenty of beautiful women are painfully insecure about their looks—he caught the impression that it was her freedom to see men other than her husband, and perhaps the frequency with which she pursued that freedom, that lent her such inner fortitude.

She smiled at Jonah as she lifted one knee to kneel on the sofa by his side.

Leaning over him, she pressed her lips to his, and without warning slipped her tongue inside his mouth. He could taste the lingering flavor of her friend's arousal on her lips, could smell it through the exotic perfume she wore, and it only made the blood pump more quickly through his swollen manhood.

“Touch her,” he heard Emma's quiet voice in his ear, almost a whisper. “She's not after romance right now.”

He complied, finding it so hot that Emma was guiding him. His hands swept down the brunette's back, over her velvet skin, around the curve of her behind.

She shuffled her knees toward him so that he could easily reach her and begin exploring her pussy.

She was seriously wet as he covered her mound and its little tab of soft dark hair, and dipped his fingers into her open petals. As he penetrated her with a finger, he squeezed her firm behind with his other hand. She was smiling at him through their kiss, her hand locked around his wrist to encourage him in thrusting his fingers inside her.

“How does she feel? I bet she's dripping wet,” came Emma's detached voice.

“You should suck on her tits, Jonah. Her nipples are so hard...”

He did as he was told, taking Tasha's stiff little bud in his hot mouth, squeezing it between his lips, sucking on it to draw out a low moan from the beautiful brunette.



She didn't give him long, though. Sitting on her haunches beside him, her hand glided over his thighs and then navigated the stiffness residing in his pants. She gave him a clear look of approval and outright lust as she unfastened his fly, drew down the zip, and curled her fingers around his rock-hard cock.

"Mmm... you're so hard..."

It took a moment to realize it was Emma's voice in his ear, not Tasha's observation. He simply wasn't used to it.

The brunette gripped the base of his shaft tight, and licked his length from bottom to tip, her tongue circling his end before she drew it inside her hot mouth.

"I bet she loves the feel of that big cock in her mouth..."

He watched her dip down, caressing his cock with the insides of her cheeks, squeezing him with her tongue, sucking on him. She was good, practiced. He stroked her silky brown hair, brushed it out of her face.

Over on the other couch, he could see the blonde kneeling on the floor over Liam's lap, her head bobbing up and down as she mirrored her friend. Liam had his hand on the back of her neck, guiding her rhythm.

"You should do that as well," Emma said. "Girls like that. Hold her head, show her how you want it."

Jonah gently pressed his hand to Tasha's head, and she let out a small moan that appeared approving. He tried a little guidance, and Tasha responded with a louder moan. She took him deeper as he held her like that, controlling her speed, and from the sounds of it was enjoying it almost as much as he was.

This was strange cock she was sucking on, and though it might have been one of many she'd enjoyed, it still carried that little frisson of pleasure simply because it was not her husband's.

Jonah found himself thinking of Emma, of how she'd looked with Clement. If he was married, he'd want to watch his wife taking this kind of pleasure. And yet, thinking of that night before he'd been able to catch

the replay on the iPad, he had experienced a strange kind of pleasure simply knowing she was doing it, she

was away somewhere being naughty, and perhaps he'd find out about it later.

Did these two women go back to their husbands and recount every little detail of their evening? Who could say? Every couple into this, it seemed, was different in how they approached it. They might share a common desire for the straying of wives, but each of their little kinks was specific to them.

While Ashley continued to suck on Liam, Tasha now picked herself up and lifted a leg over Jonah's lap. She was facing away from him, straddling his thighs, giving him only the view of the smooth skin of her lower back, her beautifully rounded rear, as she guided the tip of his cock up to her spread pussy lips.

"She wants your friend to watch her on you," Emma said, as Jonah felt the heat of Tasha's pussy press against his tip.

Jonah groaned as she sank down on him, her tight channel squeezing him, her heat intense, her wetness slick around him. Liam wasn't watching just yet.

Ashley was already echoing Tasha, though she was facing her man as she rode his lap.

Jonah slid his hands over her breasts, flicking his fingers over her prominent nipples before sweeping them down to her waist, holding her as she gently bounced on his shaft.

"No, touch her there, play with her breasts," Emma urged him, and he did so, with Tasha responding with her pace on his pole and her little soft moans, her body writhing as he cupped her and fondled her, as he crushed her nipples between thumbs and fingers.

Liam was watching her now, and she was loving it. Ashley was riding him with a more furious vigor, perhaps trying to lock down his attention. Tasha seemed to enjoy stealing a little of the other man's time from her friend. Ashley seemed to be trying it out with Jonah, too, by pushing up her butt, to expose her penetration, revealing Liam's impressive cock

each time she rose on him, the thing glistening with her juices, only then to sink down hard again.

There seemed a hint of competition in the air between these two women.

It was only friendly rivalry, though. Tasha rode herself to some kind of minor peak, and then pulled herself off Jonah, wandering over to put her arms around

Ashley and lean in for a kiss while the blonde still fucked the other man.

Then she was taking her arm, leading her away from Liam, over to an armchair.

“Go with them,” Emma said, “she’s not taking a break, trust me.”

Liam was already rising from his seat, and Jonah would have liked to think he would have gotten the hint without his little fairy helper in his ear, but he wasn’t dismissive of the guidance.

Tasha knelt on the seat of the chair as Ashley stood behind its back, the two women leaning in to each other to kiss, and stroke each others’ hair out of their faces. Both pushing out their behinds in clear invitation to the men.

Liam took a few steps with his huge cock lolling out of his pants, an almost comical sight except that Jonah was doing it too, there was really no other way.

The other man honed in on the blonde, not done with her yet, or perhaps taking full ownership for the evening. Jonah was happy enough keeping to Tasha.

He held her firm behind, eased apart her buttocks and slid back inside her, drawing out a gasp as he filled her.

Liam spent a little more time with his fingers between Ashley’s thighs before he lined up behind her and entered her again.

Jonah had a good view of Ashley’s behind being taken by the other man. She was taller than Tasha, perhaps more of a classical form than the brunette, though Jonah would have said Tasha had the prettier face.

As they were fucked from behind, the two women looked in each others' eyes, smiling, laughing, kissing, sharing the experience.

Jonah held Tasha's hips as he thrust into her with more force, the brunette becoming breathless at the sensation. Then Ashley stepped away, and underlining her partnership with her friend, she guided Liam forward, holding his cock out for Tasha to take in her mouth while Jonah continued to fuck her.

"God that's so hot..." he heard Emma's whisper in his ear, and strangely the thought of her watching this, getting off on this, struck Jonah as being as hot as the act of pounding this pretty brunette while she sucked on another man's cock.

"I have definitely got to get me some of that..."

Ashley was holding the base of Liam's shaft while her friend licked and sucked it, Liam's arm around her, clutching her breast. The other man seemed so effortlessly powerful, standing there straight, calm and collected as though he were James Bond or something.

Jonah had to focus to keep himself from finishing prematurely. Perhaps he simply wasn't as accustomed to these extraordinary experiences, this unfettered debauchery.

It was almost a relief as Ashley pulled the other man away, and Tasha rose from her knees to allow Jonah a breather.

"You're trading places, sweetie," Emma said, and her use of that affectionate term warmed him inside, somehow, as some kind of reassurance of her bond with him after their recent bust-up. "Time to give way."

He stepped around the armchair as Liam now took up position behind Tasha.

Once again it was Ashley who guided his cock to her opening, as though she was giving the man to her friend.

Jonah brushed Tasha's hair out of her face and kissed her, fondling her breasts while she reached to grab his cock. As he kissed her, he could feel

her moved by the other man's thrusting, each impact pressing her mouth to his. She moaned as she kissed him, and it wasn't from their kiss.

"You like it, don't you? Watching him take her," Emma cooed into his ear.

Then she added: "Did you enjoy watching Clement taking me?"

At her mention of her escapade, of what he had witnessed on that iPad, Jonah felt his hardness throbbing like crazy. It wasn't anything to do with Tasha now stretching her lips around his cock, despite how good that felt. It was Emma's words in his ear.

"I know you watched it. I made sure you had my iPad."

The brunette clamped her mouth around him, and he found his hands moving to her head, taking control without really thinking about it. Fucking her face in time

with the pounding that Liam was giving her other end.

Tasha's face was red, glowing with perspiration at the force with which she was being used.

"I can tell from my laptop that you watched that video," Emma said. "And you watched it all the way to the end."

Jonah thought of her having Mulray leave that iPad for him to find, thought of how he felt when he watched her with that man. The frustration he had felt, because they were not even committed boyfriend and girlfriend, how could he object to her going off with other men? Shocked by just how much he had enjoyed watching her being pleased by someone else.

Shocked by what it might mean for his future relationships. This investigation might, if he was lucky, uncover who was responsible for his brother's death. But it would also leave him indelibly marked, changed by the whole experience.

Perhaps unable to settle for a vanilla relationship again, a monogamous marriage.

He might fall for someone some day, and if his secret ever came out she would think him a freak.

“You want to share me? You want other men to sleep with me? What’s wrong with you?” a future wife might say.

Tasha could not stand the onslaught for too much longer. She withdrew from Jonah, turned and slumped down on the armchair on her back, facing up at Liam now, her legs parting to allow him reentry.

Jonah watched, wondering if he ought to be taking more of a lead, perhaps grabbing Ashley and claiming his fill of her. The blonde was hovering over them, touching herself, perhaps giving him hints and signals he was missing because his mind was drawn by the soft words in his ear.

“I stopped dating for you, Jonah,” Emma said now. “I was only seeing you. I never do that.”

What was she getting at? She was still angry with him.

Tasha reached up, grabbing his cock, pumping him while she looked up at the man fucking her. Her other hand reached up to Ashley, her fingers penetrating her friend, the blonde’s hand enclosing her wrist, holding it in place, making it look as though she was using the brunette’s hand as a sex toy.

“I mean I did love hearing about all your adventures,” Emma said, “it did turn me on. To think I might experience them through you, I suppose, but also...

well, you were just damn sexy, sleeping with all those other women.”

Jonah leaned over, kissing Tasha on the mouth as though trying to hide the fact that he was zoning out, his focus on Emma’s words.

“Only, I was being a good little girl for you? Isn’t that what men want?” she said. “But still you wanted Lily Foster. I could see it in your eyes, you wanted her. And not just for a one night stand to get information.”

Then he was putting his cock back in Tasha’s mouth, stroking her hair out of her face, penetrating her lips slowly this time.

“So... you really are becoming like those husbands, aren't you? You go for the bad girl, the ones who sleep around, who go for whatever's out there.”

It was slightly frustrating, being locked into an important conversation with Emma, but unable to state his own views. But at least he was finding out what she was thinking.

“So I feel all messed up,” she was saying. “Because I was the bad girl until I met you. Never wanted to be anything else—only, now I want you, Jonah. But do you want me? I thought I could commit to you, you'd want me. I thought maybe if I learned more about what turns you on... and I guess it's forceful women, but also women who don't limit themselves to you...”

He felt almost on autopilot for a moment, as Tasha pulled herself up from the armchair, and while she dragged Liam over to the bed, Ashley now reached out for him, dragging Jonah with her to the other side of the bed.

“So here we are, aren't we?” Emma said. “I have some catching up to do. I'm going on a date tonight. I want to know how you feel about that.”

He kissed Ashley, holding her, slowing her down, trying to get his head around

what Emma was saying even as Tasha and Liam went straight ahead and began fucking right there on the bed.

“So here you are with a nice blonde girl. You imagine she's me, coming back to you after my date with another man. After I've slept with another man. After he's fucked me to oblivion...”

Ashley looked into his eyes, a moment's uncertainty in her gaze, confusion.

What's going on?

“Show me, Jonah,” Emma said. “Show me how you feel about me after I've been such a bad girl. After I've been so royally used by another man. I need to know.”

Ashley let out a cute little squeal as Jonah threw her down onto the mattress, parted her knees and dived between her thighs. Tasha laughed at her friend's unexpected fall, but then both women were watching with mild curiosity as he began kissing and licking his way around her hairless pussy, edging closer and closer to her sensitive rosy folds.

It seemed to Jonah that they weren't expecting the men they played with to do such things. This wasn't the way City boys played. But Jonah didn't care—this wasn't for them, it was for Emma.

Ashley moaned long and low as his tongue slipped between her slippery folds.

For a moment, she turned to look at her friend being humped by the other man, teasing her, perhaps, for not having the benefit of this man's mouth.

Then as Jonah continued, her eyes closed and her head tilted back, and she was giving herself over to the sensations as he feasted on her juices, nibbled on her pussy lips and sucked gently on her clit.

"Very nice..." he heard Emma's quiet voice in his ear.

It wasn't hard to imagine this was Emma, though Ashley wasn't quite so petite, her skin not so pale, her fragrance more woody and exotic.

"You're not put off by the fact that your friend's huge great cock was fucking her earlier? Stretching out that wet pussy of hers..."

Jonah smiled faintly to himself. Actually, he surprised himself with how little that fazed him. It was just a man's body touching her, even if it was an intimate part, and he hadn't finished inside her.

"You'd go down on me after I had another man's big prick inside me?"

Jonah made a concerted effort to push his face into the blonde's body, thrusting his tongue as far into her hot, slick groove as he could, crushing her clit with his nose. He moaned to emphasize his enjoyment, to send a message to his audience.

Ashley responded with her own little cries, her body undulating under him, her nipples so hard.



And actually, Jonah did get a strange little kick from knowing he was doing something extra filthy—and imagining this was Emma’s freshly fucked pussy only boosted that arousing sense of wickedness.

“Oh, you do like that?” she couldn’t hide her surprise. “Interesting.”

Jonah felt almost as though he was showing off, taking the blonde over the edge, sliding his fingers inside her as he sucked a little more forcibly on her clit, his arms clamped around her thighs to maintain his position as her body thrashed about under him.

She came, strongly, and so very wet.

The biggest turn-on came from the moan in his ear, the sound of Emma getting off on what she was watching.

Jonah kissed his way up the blonde’s body, between her breasts as her chest rose and fell while she recovered herself. She was smiling as he reached her lips, her fingers fumbling at his neck to pull off his tie, then almost tearing off his shirt.

He could still quite easily imagine she was Emma, even while kissing her mouth.

He pulled away to remove his pants, and saw that Liam was hammering away at Tasha from behind, the brunette now leaning over to kiss Ashley while she lay exposed for Jonah. The other man was still wearing his suit, minus the jacket, and really slamming himself into the pretty brunette.

“Are you still picturing me down there on the bed, waiting for you to fuck me?”

came Emma’s voice after an extended silence.

Kneeling between Ashley’s open thighs, Jonah let out a moan that could easily be read as an affirmative response to Emma’s question.

“You don’t mind that I’ve just enjoyed someone else’s cock right there? I’m dirty, I’m such a bad girl...”

He held Ashley’s ankles, lifted her legs and let his long hard cock rest against her wet pussy. Pumping his hips, he stroked his manhood back

and forth over her, without yet penetrating her, drawing out the sighs and moans while she continued to suck on her friend's face.

She had just taken Liam inside her, so he didn't have to go far to imagine this was Emma after she had been with someone else. It didn't put him off. If anything, it stirred some primeval force within him, some component of his masculinity that drove him to compete in order to spread his genes.

"How does it feel? She's been used by someone else, polluted."

He let out another moan to show Emma how turned on he was by the idea, and then directed his tip into her, both women now watching him enter her, Ashley open-mouthed and groaning in response to his filling of her hot pussy.

"Fuck me, Jonah, fuck your dirty girl..."

He could hear Emma in his ear, echoing the moans of the other blonde as he lay over her, squeezing his body against her as he pumped his hips to thrust his cock forcefully inside her.

As he fucked her, he kissed Ashley's soft neck, and held her round breasts firmly in his hands. Her skin was so soft, her body so toned and taut, but he still imagined it was Emma under him, and with the sound of her in his ear, it was a fully immersive experience.

"Fuck me.... fuck me... come inside me..."

His pace accelerated as his orgasm approached, and Ashley was writhing under him, taking herself with him. But then she came, and he did not. He was able to control himself, halt the charge. It hadn't really happened this way before, his

abilities in the bedroom had improved during his sexual journey.

Ashley seemed surprised that he pulled out, urged her over onto all fours with plenty of gentle touches over her beautiful velvet skin. Tasha was done, laid out with Liam collapsed over her. But Jonah was still going, caressing her shapely behind, edging in to press his tongue against her sensitive pussy lips, reacquainting himself with her flavor while recovering his breath.

Fucking her from behind seemed to gel with the biological imperative he had to reclaim this blonde beauty from the other man, whether she was Ashley or the imagined Emma. It was more animalistic, less civilized. He could pound her hard, and yet more slowly, savoring the feeling of his swollen manhood grazing against every part of her tight channel.

He felt powerful, mounting her, claiming her, rocking her world.

If Emma was going to have other lovers, then Jonah felt he was going to have to step up a gear to make sure she was most excited to come back to him afterwards.

When he finally allowed himself to come, he was holding her tight, spooning over her, his body fitting hers like a glove.

By that time, she was crying quietly, “Please... please... please...”

But it was still Emma in his head as he released himself, and filled her with his hot seed.



They dressed while the wives continued to play amongst themselves on the bed, but once ready to take their leave, Ashley and Tasha descended from the bed to bid them farewell.

Jonah could breathe in the scent of sex from their naked bodies as they draped themselves over him for a goodbye kiss. It made him think how it might be getting Emma back after she'd been with another man—made him feel a little giddy, and things thickening slightly down below.

Tasha subtly drew white envelopes from behind an urn on the mantelpiece above the fireplace, to hand to the men on their way out. Jonah didn't need to open his envelope to know that it would contain a little white card bearing black printed letters.

“Our reward, huh?” Jonah said, indicating the envelope as they descended the narrow staircase toward ground level. He was trying to sound as though he was merely casually referring to what these letters meant,

rather than attempting to garner some kind of confirmation from an insider.

But Liam gave him what he wanted, saying: “Uh-huh. Nice to hit your targets for the month early, right?”

“Right.”

As they parted ways out on the street in front of the hotel, Liam gave him a mock salute, said: “Probably see you tonight, right?” Then he was away in the crowd of scurrying shoppers.



Jonah saw her at the last moment, leaning up against the cast iron railings that prevented people on the street from falling down to the basement level.

Then she jumped on him, kissing his mouth as full-on as though they were still together.

“You were fantastic!” her eyes were all lit up.

“You want to go somewhere, maybe discuss it?” Jonah couldn’t help smiling as he took off the glasses, and handed them along with the earpiece to her.

“Oh, I can’t. I nearly forgot—I’m going to a thing tonight.”

“A thing? Tonight?”

“Well, it’s south of the river. I’ve got to get ready for it, you know? Find the right outfit...”

“It’s what, another date with your new guy? Clement Whatever-He’s-Called?”

Jonah couldn’t hide the disappointment from his voice, but it drew out an expression of pity from Emma, which felt like a tiny victory at least.

“No—this is completely different. It’s a big party. Should be lots of fun.”

“Oh, right—”

Jonah sighed. Just for the night, he wanted her to pause her big adventure, her personal exploration. He wanted her so badly. But he had no idea how long she intended to keep this whole split thing going.

Emma hailed a taxi that was sauntering up the street toward the leafy Soho Square. She said, “It’s going to be great for getting an idea of how big this Network is, what kind of organization it is, don’t you think?”

Jonah felt his stomach burn. This big party she was talking about—

“Wait, this is a Network thing you’re going to tonight?” he yelled above the loud clacking of the cab’s diesel engine echoing in the narrow street.

“Biggest one of the year!” Emma yelled back.

The event Lady Moss was going to. The reason why he was supposed to go back with Keeley to break into her house. Emma was going to it? How on Earth had she got an invitation? She was going while Jonah, who needed every insight he possibly could on the Network, was frozen out.

Jonah felt stunned. And if the Network was one massive organization based around the shared pleasures of wife-sharing—what was Emma going to have to do at its biggest event of the year?

But he had no way of stopping her, not now.

“I’ll see you soon,” she blew him a kiss as she hopped into the black cab. Then, out of the window, “I miss you, sweetie.”

And she was gone.

Jonah pulled his phone out of his pocket, and quickly found her number. He winced as it went straight to voicemail.

What had Reynolds said to Lady Moss about the “Breeding Party” to which Emma was now going? That as a member, she was obliged to go to the event, even if only to watch rather than participate. If the Black Widow was indeed a member of the Network—and Jonah had every reason

to believe she was—then that would mean she would be obliged to attend the event, too, whoever she was.

Emma would be under the same roof as a vicious murderer, and if she was found to be asking too many questions about the Hotel Killings, she would be putting herself in serious danger.

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A romantic scene featuring a couple in an intimate embrace on a dark couch. The man is shirtless, and the woman is wearing a light-colored t-shirt and white shorts. In the foreground, two glasses of red wine are visible on a dark surface. The text "more hot wives exploring other men..." is overlaid in a white serif font.

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